

Clear pending cases, transport minister warns RTO officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh conducted an unannounced surprise inspection of the Regional Transport Office at Raja Garden on Thursday. During the inspection drive, the minister found over 1,000 pending cases awaiting disposal and immediately directed officials to clear the entire backlog within 10 days, with a warning that negligence or failure to meet the deadline will invite strict disciplinary action against responsible officers.

Singh walked through the RTO's service counters, reviewed the functional layout, audited pending applications, and directly interacted with citizens who had come to the office for various transport-related work, gathering firsthand feedback about administrative delays and bottlenecks.

He said the backlog was



unacceptable and directed officials to submit a comprehensive compliance report within 10 days. "Directions have been issued to clear all pending cases within the prescribed timeline, and a detailed report has been sought within ten days. Any negligence or failure to reduce the backlog will invite strict action against the concerned officials," he said.

Citizens at the RTO raised concerns about repeated visits caused by technical glitches on transport portals.

Singh directed the technical and administrative teams to resolve the system errors on priority to ensure smooth processing for driving licences, vehicle registrations, ownership transfers, and related services.

He also directed RTO staff to stop calling applicants to the office unnecessarily. Since the majority of transport-related services are available online, physical presence should be required only in exceptional cases where document verification or presence is legally

mandatory, he said.

The inspection follows citizen complaints about delays at one of Delhi's prominent RTOs. Raja Garden RTO handles a large volume of applications from west and central Delhi, making its backlog a concern that affects a significant number of applicants who may have been waiting weeks or months for their cases to be processed.

The Transport Minister's visit is part of a broader Statewide initiative by the department to monitor RTO functioning, improve accountability, and reduce the need for citizens to make repeated visits for services that should be processed within defined timelines. Singh said the Delhi Government under Chief Minister Rekha Gupta is committed to providing transparent, efficient, and citizen-friendly governance and that all RTOs across Delhi will continue to be monitored.

LG visits Aerocity, reviews infrastructure works

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu visited Aerocity, where GMR officials gave him a detailed presentation on ongoing infrastructure development works in the area.

On the occasion, the LG directed that green infrastructure and sustainability principles remain at the core of all future planning, and emphasised the need for close coordination between DDA and GMR, given Aerocity's strategic proximity to Dwarka.

The visit formed part of the LG's ongoing engagement with key growth nodes in the capital, aimed at reviewing on-the-ground progress and aligning private infrastructure development with the city's broader urban planning priorities.

During the visit, Sandhu held detailed discussions on sustainable urban planning for Aerocity, reviewing how



upcoming infrastructure works are being designed to support long-term planned growth. Discussions covered the robustness of water conservation and flood management systems being put in place, with a focus on ensuring the area remains resilient to waterlogging and flooding during the monsoon season.

The LG also reviewed measures being undertaken for efficient traffic management in and around Aerocity, which witnesses significant vehicular movement owing to its proximity to the airport and its emergence as a major commercial and hospitality hub.

Plans for seamless last-mile Metro connectivity were discussed, which the LG noted was essential to easing congestion and improving accessibility for commuters and visitors.

Sandhu emphasised the need for close coordination between DDA and GMR, given Aerocity's proximity to Dwarka, which he described as a key growth corridor for Delhi's future.

The LG's emphasis on flood management and water conservation at Aerocity is particularly relevant given the waterlogging that affected large parts of Delhi on July 28.

Namo Bharat staff rescue child, reunite family

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Alert staff at the Sarai Kale Khan Namoo Bharat station helped reunite a young child with his family after becoming suspicious of a woman accompanying the child, prompting intervention by security personnel and the police, the NCRTC said on Thursday.



about her relationship with the child.

The woman claimed that the child was her son, but the child denied knowing her, following which the matter was immediately reported to the Station Controller.

The Station Controller alerted personnel of the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) deployed at

the station and informed the Delhi Police, it stated.

The child's parents were also contacted, and both the woman and the child were handed over to the police for further investigation, the statement said.

NCRTC Managing Director Shalabh Goel appreciated the station staff for their vigilance and prompt response, saying their alertness helped avert a possible untoward incident.

The corporation said this was not the first such case. In September last year, real-time CCTV monitoring at Anand Vihar Namoo Bharat station helped identify three minor girls travelling with four adult men.

Govt to launch Family Card for all households

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government is planning to introduce a 'Family Card' for all the households in the national Capital with the primary objective of creating a unified database of all families in the city. The 'Family Card' will have all the information regarding the family members, whether they are availing benefits under any existing schemes of the Government, their birth and death details, etc.

A top Delhi Government official said that the Government will issue a Family Card to every household in Delhi. The aim is to



create an authentic and verified database, which will help us in planning future public welfare, healthcare schemes and projects.

Similar steps have been taken by the neighbouring state of Haryana, where they have launched a 'Parivar Pehchan Patra', a family identification card containing all

details about the unit. "The family card will provide better coordination among departments; for example, vaccination among children and this card will help in tracking whether all the children are vaccinated or not," the officer added.

Recently, the Government approved the 'Delhi Lakshmi Yojna' aimed at providing financial aid to women, with several conditions, except for those having more than three living children.

"Under the scheme, we have added that condition because, indirectly, we also want to help those women who may be pressurised into giving birth to more children for the sake of a boy.

We have observed this in lower-middle-class families, so this scheme will support those women as well," Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said.

The Government has earmarked ₹5,110 crore under the 2026-27 Budget for the scheme.

"Under the proposed norms, applicants will have to submit a self-declaration stating they have been residents of Delhi for at least 10 years and have no criminal record," a senior official said.

According to the scheme guidelines approved by the Cabinet, women between 21 and 60 years of age whose family income is up to ₹2.50 lakh per annum will be eligible to apply.

ITL FINLEASE AND SECURITIES LTD

CIN: L65910DL1991PLC045090

Registered Office:-B-08, GD-ITL Tower, Top Floor, Netaji Subhash Place, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, E-Mail: cs@itlfinlease@gmail.com, Website: www.itlfinlease.in, Ph No- 01141572981

Un-Audited Financial Results for the quarter ended on June 30, 2026

Based on the recommendation of the audit committee, the Board of Directors of ITL Finlease and Securities Limited ("the Company") at its meeting held on Wednesday, July 29, 2026, has approved the Unaudited Financial Results for the Quarter ended June 30, 2026. The said financial results along with the limited review report of the Statutory Auditor thereon are available on the website of the Stock Exchange www.mseil.in and Company's website www.itlfinlease.in. The same can also be accessed by scanning a Quick Response Code given below:



Scan the QR Code to access the Financial Results on the Website of the Company

For ITL FINLEASE AND SECURITIES LTD
Sd/-
B.L. GUPTA
DIRECTOR
Date : 29-07-2026
Place : DELHI
DIN NO-00143031

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of DIPTI MINU who is purchasing Flat No. C-4, on Third Floor, measuring 600 Sq. Feet., (approx.), of Property bearing No.893-A/6, comprised in Kharsa No.115/12 Min. Situated at Village Mehrauli, Tehsil Mehrauli, New Delhi-110030 New Delhi, from Mohd. Zakir who had owned the subject property vide Notarized General Power of Attorney Agreement to sell and Will dated 28.06.2022, executed by Mr. Satish Kumar, now DIPTI MINU intend to purchase and mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD So. to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.

Lucem Legal LLP
N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049
Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of Mrs. Shama Parveen who is owner of Property bearing No.B-201, area measuring 57.1/2 sq. yds., out of area measuring 150 sq. yds., comprised in Kharsa No.108/4 situated in the area of village Ghonda Gurjan Khadar in the abadi of Gali No. 6, Subhash Mohalla, Ghonda Ilaqa Shahdara, Delhi-110053, who had owned the subject property vide Gift Deed dated 21.07.2026 bearing Document No. 2026/12/2707, Book No. 1, Volume No.8846, on Page No.23-44, dated 27.07.2026. Sd/-North East Seelampur IV, Delhi executed by Mr. Firoz Ahmad, now Mrs. Shama Parveen intend to mortgage the subject property with VASTU HOUSING FINANCE CORPORATION LTD So. to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/title/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 07 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc.

Lucem Legal LLP
N-161, Ground Floor, Saira Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre New Delhi-110049
Contact # 011-40046316 & 41667327

CAPRI

CIN No.: L65921MH1994PLC173469

Regd. Office: 502, Tower A, Peninsula Business Park, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013

Website: www.capri loans.in | Tel: +91 22 43548100; Fax: +91 22 40888160

NOTICE

NOTICE is hereby given that the Company would be closing the branch at the following locations:

Name of Branch	Address	Date of Closing	Purpose	New Address
Mathura - ML	Ramiz Elevate, First Floor, 169/20 Gausala Road Opposite BSA Road Mathura, Uttar Pradesh, Pincode: 281004	Jul 31, 2026	Shifting to other location in same city	Plot No 217/489, Kharsa No 519 and 520, 2nd Floor, Ratan Square, Bhuteswar Road, Mathura, Uttar Pradesh, Pincode: 281001
Bareilly-ML	Kothi No. 82 A/7, Banke Nekpur Chaulpa Civil Lines, Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh, Pincode: 243001	Jul 31, 2026	Shifting to other location in same city	2nd Floor, Sheetal Tikla Tower, 88-C/3, Opp. Hind Cinema, Civil Lines, Bareilly, Uttar Pradesh, Pincode: 243001

for Capri Global Capital Limited
Sd/-
(Authorised Signatory)

Place: Uttar Pradesh
Date: July 31, 2026

ESAF

ESAF SMALL FINANCE BANK

REGD. OFFICE: ESAF Bhavan, Mannuthy, Thrissur- 680 651, Kerala

GOLD AUCTION NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the public that gold ornaments pledged with ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd. against various loan accounts remaining overdue/unredeemed despite repeated notices will be auctioned for recovery of the Bank's dues, in accordance with applicable banking regulations and policies.

DETAILS OF AUCTION

Mode of Auction: Off-line (Physical Auction through Branches)	
Date of Auction: 03-09-2026	Time: 11:00 AM to 01:00 PM
Auction Venues: The auction will be conducted at the following ESAF Small Finance Bank branches in Haryana	
Interested bidders are requested to visit the respective branches for participation. For detailed branch addresses and contact numbers, please visit the Bank's official website	
BRANCH NAME - LOAN ACCOUNT NUMBER	
Faridabad: 63260000312343.	

Important Instructions: Borrowers may redeem their pledged gold ornaments by clearing the total dues along with applicable charges at least two days prior to the auction date. Interested bidders must carry valid KYC documents. GST Registration Number is mandatory for firms/companies, wherever applicable. Bidders are required to deposit an Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of Rs.2,500 before participating in the auction. The auction will be conducted on an "as is where is" and "as is what is" basis. The Bank reserves the right to cancel/postpone the auction or reject any bid without assigning any reason. Participation in the auction shall be deemed acceptance of all terms and conditions of the Bank. The Minimum Reserve Price will be fixed by bank on the basis of IBAJ Rate as applicable on the basis of purity of Gold.

Place: Thrissur
Date: 31-07-2026
(Sd/-) Authorized Signatory
ESAF Small Finance Bank Ltd.

SMFG Grihashakti

SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.

Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051. Regd. Off.: Commerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES

E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE OF 15 DAYS FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE ASSETS UNDER THE SECURITISATION AND RECONSTRUCTION OF FINANCIAL ASSETS AND ENFORCEMENT OF SECURITY INTEREST ACT, 2002 READ WITH PROVISION TO RULE 9(1) OF THE SECURITY INTEREST (ENFORCEMENT) RULES, 2002. NOTICE is hereby given to the Public in General and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below listed immovable properties ("Secured Assets") mortgaged / charged to the Secured Creditor, the Possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd. (hereinafter referred to as SMHFC) ("Secured Creditor"), will be sold on "As is where is", "As is what is" and "Whatever there is" on the date and time mentioned herein below, for recovery of the dues mentioned herein below and further interest and other expenses thereon till date of realization, due to SMHFC Secured Creditor from the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) mentioned herein below.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of the Properties	Reserve Price : Earnest Money Deposit :	Date & Time of E-Auction	Date of EMD Submission
1.	1. Roop Singh, S/o. Jawahar Khan 2. Mithalesh Devi, W/o. Roop Singh	Plot No. 226, Measuring Area 83.61 Sq. Mtrs. Land Bearing Kharsa No. 220, Girraj Vatika, Mauza Ronchi Bangur, Tehsil & District Mathura. Boundaries - East : Plot No. 191; West : Rasta 18 Feet Wide; North : Plot No. 225; South : Plot No. 227	Rs. 23,90,000/-	20.08.2026 at 11.00 a. m.	19.08.2026 to 01.00 p. m.
			Rs. 2,39,000/-	01.00 p. m.	
2.	1. Sameer Khan, S/o. Anwar Khan 2. Anwar Khan, S/o. Anwar Khan 3. Nagina, W/o. Anwar Khan	A Shop Measuring Area 15.53 Sq. Mtrs. Shop No. 105, First Floor, Mohalla Goundiy Nagar, Masani Tehsil & Dist. Mathura, UP. Boundaries - East : Shop No. 104; West : Shop No.106; North : Land Lord Firm; South : Road Shop Gallery.	Rs. 8,80,000/-	20.08.2026 at 11.00 a. m.	19.08.2026 to 01.00 p. m.
			Rs. 88,000/-	01.00 p. m.	

Details terms and conditions of the sale are as below and the details are also provided in our/secured creditor's website at the following link website address: <https://bid0deal.in> and <https://www.grihashakti.com/pdf/E-Auction.pdf> The Intending Bidders can also Contact : Pankaj Kumar, Mobile: 7380950199, E-mail : Pankaj.Kumar38@grihashakti.com, Mr. Niloy Dey, on his Mob. 8655619157, E-mail : Niloy.Dey@grihashakti.com

Place : Mathura, Uttar Pradesh
Date : 23.07.2026
Sd/-
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

PUBLIC NOTICE

TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN
Notice is hereby given to the general public that my clients, Mohd. Aslam Khan, Mohd. Abrar Khan, Mrs. Seema Khan, Mrs. Aniba Khan, and Mrs. Nighat Rehman, R/o H. No. 902/14, Nadir Ali Building, Meerut, Uttar Pradesh, are the legal heirs of Late Mohd. Wasal Khan S/o Mohd. Qasim Khan. My clients intend to sell/transfer their right, title, and interest in the property bearing Kharsa No. 218, measuring 2 bigha 14 biswa, situated at Village Sikdarpur, now Babir Nagar, Shahdara, Delhi.

Any person, bank, financial institution, or entity claiming any right, title, interest, share, lien, charge, mortgage, lease, gift, easement, dispute, maintenance claim, or other encumbrance in respect of the said property is requested to present written objections/claims along with certified supporting documents, to the undersigned within 14 days from the date of publication of this notice. If no objection or claim is received within the said period, the property shall be presumed clear, marketable, and free from encumbrance. My clients shall then proceed with the sale/transfer, and any later claim or objection shall be deemed waived, invalid, and non-binding upon my clients or any prospective purchaser.

Place: Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that PRATYUSH MUHURI son of PRANAB KUMAR MUHURI is applying to the Secretary to the Government of India in the Ministry of Home Affairs for naturalization and that any person who knows any reason why naturalization should not be granted should send a written signed statement of the facts to the said Secretary

PUBLIC NOTICE

Flat No.M-27/A-3, Janta Flat, Ground Flat Floor, Dilshad Garden, Delhi-110095, Shri Pramod Kumar S/o Shri Jagdish Raj have lost the DDA documents 1. Demand Letter 2. Possession-cum-Allotment Letter 3. Possession Slip 4. NOC (Electricity & Water connection) for M-27/A-3, Janta Flat, Ground Flat Floor, Dilshad Garden, Delhi-110095 have also NCR in Police Station vide LR No.241349/2021.

Manohar Chandra (Advocate)

PUBLIC NOTICE

To Whom so ever it may concern
Bajaj Capital Insurance
Broking Ltd. has shifted Ghaziabad office situated at plot no. 12 C/506 first floor, bhatt tower, sector 12, vasundhara ghaziabad up - 201012. has been shifted to New Delhi. From now all services will be provided by BCIBL , 5th Floor, Bajaj House, Nehru Place New Delhi - 110019. For any information contact our Centralized Customer service Team Toll-Free 7678123123 between 10 to 6 pm, Monday-Saturday.
Note:- Do not pay cash for any reason to anyone claiming to be employee of Bajaj Capital Insurance Broking Ltd.
(BCIBL) is an IRDAI licensed Composite Broker bearing licence no. 241. dated 09/01/2025 valid till 08/01/2028 (originally licensed on 09/01/2004 and renewed thereafter)

General Public may also take note that any transaction done by anybody on the basis of the said document or any of the said document shall be illegal and not binding on our clients. The person doing so shall be liable to be prosecuted under the law.

SHIVKANT ARORA, ADVOCATE
FOR MIS/INTELLECTUAL LAW OFFICES
A-74, LOWER GROUND FLOOR,
DEFENCE COLONY, NEW DELHI-110024

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Santosh Kumar W/o Late Shri Narinder Mohan Malhotra, R/o House No. 1445, Sector 15, Faridabad-121007, have changed my name to Santosh Malhotra and shall hereafter be known by this name for all purposes.

I, Abhinav Mittal, S/o Manoj Kumar Mittal, residing at 43, Pratap Khand, Vishwakarma Nagar, Delhi-110095, do hereby solemnly declare that Manoj Kumar Mittal and Manoj Mittal are one and the same person, and that he shall hereafter be known as Manoj Kumar Mittal for all future purposes.

I Vinit Kumar S/o Vimal Kumar Singh R/o 724/9, Ambedkar Nagar, Haiderpur Village, Delhi-110088 declare that VINIT KUMAR and BINIT KUMAR both are same person.

I, Kailash, Mother of No.16022648Y Rfn Pawan Kumar, R/o- VPO- Sarsana, Teh.- Hisar, Distt- Hisar, Haryana- 125001, have changed my name from Kailash to Kailashpati, vide affidavit dated 30/07/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

LAWYER SEEKS BETTER MOBILE NETWORK IN DELHI COURTS

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An advocate has written to the principal district judges of the Tis Hazari and Karkardooma court complexes, highlighting persistent mobile network issues in the premises and seeking installation of signal-enhancing infrastructure to improve connectivity for lawyers, litigants and court staff.

In separate representations dated July 30, advocate Manish Jain said weak mobile signals inside various court buildings were causing difficulties in communication and affecting the functioning of court users.



The lawyer pointed out that the problem was being faced in the main buildings as well as the newer and annex blocks of the two court complexes. According to the representations, poor network coverage often disrupts phone calls, internet access and digital communication, making it difficult for advocates to coordinate with clients, access case-related information and receive important updates during court proceedings.

Jain said litigants visiting the courts also face inconvenience as they are unable to contact family members, lawyers or other concerned persons due to weak signal strength inside the buildings.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Re: Flat No. 2198 on Ground Floor, Green Flat, DDA Rajouri Garden, New Delhi - 110027 hereinafter called referred as the 'said property'.
NOTICE is hereby given to general public that our clients Mrs. Aastha Grover and Mr. Yuvraj Aneja (hereinafter referred as the 'Purchasers') intending to purchase the said property from Mrs. Manoj Kaur (hereinafter referred as 'seller') who owned the said property vide Relinquishment Deed dated 24.07.2019 executed by Mr. Abhijit Singh and Sonica, registered as registration No.26520, in Book No.1, pages no.81-87, vol.no.5008 on dated 31.12.2019, at the office Sub Registrar-IIB. The said seller has informed that Original Conveyance Deed regd. on 28.10.1994 executed by POI in favour of Mrs. Harinder Kaur Arora forming part of chain documents, is hereinafter called the 'said document' has been lost/misplaced and is not traceable. A FIR to this effect has also been lodged with West District Crime Branch, Delhi, Rajouri Garden/Police Station, vide LR No. 493858/2026 dated 30/07/2026.
If the aforesaid original document (the said document) or any one of them is found or has been found by any person, the same may be returned and delivered to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below. Further, if any person, body, institution is having any claim and/or objection in respect of the said property, neither may raise his/ their objection/s, in writing, with documentary evidence/s, by Registered AD Post, to the undersigned at the address mentioned herein below within 07 days of publication of this notice. Otherwise, after expiry of 07days from the date of publication of this notice, no objection shall be acceptable.
General Public may also take note that any transaction done by anybody on the basis of the said document or any of the said document shall be illegal and not binding on our clients. The person doing so shall be liable to be prosecuted under the law.

SHIVKANT ARORA, ADVOCATE
FOR MIS/INTELLECTUAL LAW OFFICES
A-74, LOWER GROUND FLOOR,
DEFENCE COLONY, NEW DELHI-110024

Govt to roll out property Aadhaar cards, land records bill: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Thursday that the Delhi Government is preparing the Land Records Bill, 2026 and planning to introduce property Aadhaar cards for each property in the city.

Once the law comes into force, every property in Delhi will undergo a scientific survey and a comprehensive digital record will be created. Each property will then be assigned a unique 'Property Aadhaar Card'. A special session of the Delhi Legislative Assembly will be convened for the Bill.

The Chief Minister said the initiative draws on the model of the Aadhaar card, which gives every citizen a trusted form of identity. She said every property in Delhi will similarly get a secure and authentic digital identity, making land records more transparent and technologically sound.

The move builds on a pilot project already completed under the Central Government's SVAMITVA scheme. In its first phase, the Delhi Government prepared smart property cards for 30 rural villages using drone surveys and technical support from the Survey of India.

Officials said the pilot succeeded in creating authenticated property records for rural areas and cutting down the scope for future land disputes. Lal Dora areas — village habitation zones marked in red ink in revenue records, used for both agricultural and non-agricultural purposes with certain construction restrictions - have long lacked systematic, authenticated property records.

The new Bill will extend this exercise well beyond villages. It will cover every residential, commercial and other category of property across urban Delhi as well. A separate digital record will be



created for each floor of every building, so that no property is left outside the survey.

The Chief Minister said the absence of a systematic land records system has for decades created problems for residents trying to prove ownership, complete

property transactions, settle inheritance matters, secure loans, get building plans approved, or resolve pending court disputes. She said the new digital records will remove this ambiguity, improve transparency and reduce disputes linked to

land ownership. The Chief Minister described the project as more than a record-keeping exercise, calling it a foundation for Delhi's future digital governance system. She said the records, built using drone surveys and digital mapping, will help the Government offer more reliable and efficient services to citizens going forward.

The Chief Minister explained that the SVAMITVA property card system relies on advanced digital technology developed with technical support from the Survey of India, combined with drone-based surveys. The same technology will now be used across Delhi to prepare the

Property Aadhaar Card for every property in the Capital, marking what she called a new era in land records management. She added that the Delhi Land Records Bill, 2026 is currently going through the approval process after detailed review by a Group of Ministers. Once enacted, the legislation will assign a Unique Property ID to every property in Delhi through its Property Aadhaar Card.

The Government has not yet announced a timeline for when the citywide survey will begin or when the special Assembly session will be held. Officials are expected to release further details once

the Bill clears the remaining stages of approval.

The initiative marks one of the most ambitious urban land record reforms attempted in the Capital, aiming to bring millions of properties, from single-floor homes to multi-storey commercial complexes, under one unified digital system for the first time. So far, 12,232 properties have been surveyed, of which 8,423 (nearly 69%) are dispute-free, with all surveyed properties in South and North West districts fully resolved. Records will eventually be integrated in real time with the Delhi Online Registration Information System (DORIS).

1,025 defaulters to face DJB sealing action

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Jal Board (DJB) has issued notices to over a thousand commercial property owners who owe massive amounts in unpaid water bills, warning them of property sealing if dues are not cleared by August 15, 2026.

Delhi Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh announced on Thursday that the board has identified 1,025 commercial properties with outstanding water bills of ₹25 lakh or more, built up over several years. He said the Government has given these defaulters a final window to settle their accounts before facing legal action. The minister said the DJB is legally empowered to attach and seal properties belonging to persistent defaulters. He made clear that action would follow automatically once the deadline lapses. "So far, we have identified 1,025 commercial properties with outstanding water bills of ₹25 lakh or more accumulated over the years. If they fail to pay within



the given deadline, appropriate action will be taken in accordance with the rules," Singh said.

The crackdown is linked to the Late Payment Surcharge Waiver Scheme, first launched last year for household consumers and later extended to commercial users. The scheme allows defaulters to pay off their principal dues while getting significant relief on accumulated penalty charges.

Singh said commercial consumers are also eligible to benefit from this waiver scheme. He expressed hope that the initiative would

boost recovery of pending payments and improve the DJB's financial health.

According to figures shared by the minister, the Delhi Government is aiming to recover close to ₹5,000 crore in unpaid principal water dues. Alongside this recovery drive, the government is offering relief by waiving off nearly ₹11,000 crore worth of accumulated late payment surcharge across consumers.

Singh clarified that strict enforcement measures against defaulters will kick in only after the waiver scheme window closes. He reiterated that the scheme remains

valid until August 15, 2026, after which non-compliant consumers will face consequences under existing legal provisions. "The LPSC Waiver Scheme is currently valid till August 15, 2026. Those who do not clear their dues within this period will face action under the applicable provisions of the law," he said.

The scheme's benefits have been structured in phases. Consumers who cleared their outstanding principal dues by January 31, 2026, received a full, 100 per cent waiver on their late payment surcharge. Those making payments after that date are currently entitled to a 70 per cent waiver on the surcharge amount.

The Delhi Government appears to be using a mix of incentives and deterrents to push through the recovery drive, offering substantial relief to those who pay up while signalling firm action against those who continue to default. With the deadline just over two weeks away, the coming days are expected to see a rush among commercial property owners looking to avoid penal action.

CCTV footage shows CJP protesters reached 100 metres of Parliament

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

New CCTV footage shows Cockroach Janata Party (CJP) protesters getting within 100 metres of Parliament during their 'Chalo Sansad' march on July 20. The videos, recorded by several cameras in the high-security area, show the crowd clashing with police, breaking through barriers, and getting dangerously close to Parliament. These images point to major security lapses in the heart of the Capital.

Scuffles broke out as police tried to hold back the crowd. Officers struggled to push the protesters away, and the temporary barricades looked unfinished or too weak to stop them. These scenes have raised serious questions about how ready the Delhi Police were, how strong the barricades were, and whether the prohibitory orders under Section 163 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita were enforced that day. Section 163 lets authorities ban gatherings in sensitive



areas to prevent incidents like this. But the footage suggests the order was not enforced properly.

The area also looked short-staffed. Permanent concrete barriers and mobile steel barricades, which usually form several layers of defence around Parliament, did not seem strong enough. If there were any intelligence warnings about the size of the march, they did not lead to enough police being deployed in time. Police sources say the situation was eventually brought under control and that no protester entered the Parliament premises.

More police units were sent in, and the crowd was

pushed back after the first breach. Still, the new videos show that in the early moments, there was confusion, physical clashes, and a lack of coordinated response. Security experts say that protesters getting within 100 metres of Parliament is a serious failure, especially for such a heavily guarded place. This incident has renewed worries about how well India's democratic institutions are protected.

Any prolonged presence of an agitated crowd so close to the Parliament carries risks that go beyond traffic disruption or routine law-and-order management. Questions are now being asked about why standard operating procedures for high-threat zones appeared to fail, whether the police had accurate real-time intelligence on the size and intent of the gathering, and whether inter-agency coordination between the Delhi Police, Parliament security and central forces was effective.

Political reactions followed soon after. Critics of the gov-

ernment are using the footage to demand a clear investigation into possible failures. Government supporters argue that since the protest was eventually contained, the system worked and that single video clips should not cause alarm. The 'Chalo Sansad' march was announced in advance by CJP, giving officials time to prepare, but the planning appears to have been poorly handled.

This incident has once again shown how difficult it is to balance the right to protest with the need to protect the country's main institutions from disruption or violence. As the videos continue to spread, there is growing pressure on the Delhi Police and the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA) to explain what happened. Allowing protesters to get within 100 metres of Parliament is a serious issue and cannot be brushed aside as a minor mistake. In a city that houses the country's top institutions, people are demanding real answers.

Jantar Mantar under tight security a week after CJP protest ends, civic agencies restore site

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

A week after the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) called off its mass agitation over the NEET paper leak, Delhi's iconic protest venue at Jantar Mantar has largely returned to normal. Traffic is flowing freely, shops have resumed business and civic authorities have cleared the debris left behind by weeks of demonstrations. Yet, heavy security deployment at the site suggests authorities are not taking any chances.

A visit by *The Pioneer* to Jantar Mantar on Thursday found the main protest area still barricaded, with a strong

presence of Delhi Police personnel and Rapid Action Force (RAF) teams. Visitors entering the designated protest area were subjected to frisking, bag checks and security screening before being allowed inside.

The visible security presence comes despite the CJP ending its 36-day protest on July 25 after the Centre accepted several of its demands, including the resignation of Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. The Government had also assured the withdrawal of FIRs registered against protesters and announced compensation for families of NEET aspirants who died by suicide following

the examination controversy. However, the administration appears to be preparing for the possibility of fresh demonstrations. CJP leaders, including Abhijeet Dipke, Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, have publicly urged governments to honour their commitments, warning that they would be "forced to return to the streets" if the promises were not fulfilled. While several state governments have initiated the process of withdrawing cases against protesters, the exercise remains incomplete in some states.

Security agencies are also maintaining heightened vigilance as the Monsoon Session



of Parliament continues, since Jantar Mantar remains a key venue for demonstrations in the national Capital.

"Security is tight because of the recent protests. Barricading will remain at Jantar Mantar," a Delhi Police personnel deployed at the site told *The Pioneer*.

Even as security remains on high alert, civic restoration work is still underway. The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) and other agencies have removed garbage accumulated during the prolonged sit-in and repainted walls and police barricades that had been covered with

slogans and graffiti related to the NEET paper leak and alleged examination irregularities. Contractors were also seen carrying out painting and welding work at multiple locations inside the protest zone on Thursday.

Despite speculation on social media that Jantar Mantar had been permanently closed for protests following the CJP agitation, Delhi Police has dismissed such claims as misleading, clarifying that peaceful demonstrations continue to be permitted after following due procedures. The claim is also reflected on the ground. On July 29, members of Left-affiliated student organisations

staged a protest at Jantar Mantar against alleged police excesses during the CJP demonstrations. On Thursday, a small political outfit was also holding a demonstration at the venue, indicating that protest activity has resumed, albeit on a much smaller scale.

Authorities had also anticipated fresh gatherings after a retired police officers' association announced a protest on July 30 over alleged attacks on police personnel during the CJP agitation, though the event did not materialise. Another transport union has announced a "Sansad March" on July 31 over the E20 petrol issue, adding to the adminis-

tration's cautious approach. Outside the barricaded protest zone, however, normalcy has largely returned. Shops and eateries around Jantar Mantar were functioning as usual, with a steady flow of customers replacing the thousands of protesters, volunteers and security personnel who had occupied the area until last week.

While the protest has ended, the continued barricading, intensive security checks and ongoing restoration work underline the administration's determination to remain prepared for any fresh mobilisation in the politically sensitive Parliament Street area.

DoE finds major violations at Vikaspuri school

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government on Thursday issued a show-cause notice to the management of a private school in Vikaspuri after an inspection by the Directorate of Education (DoE) allegedly found multiple safety, administrative and financial violations, including the operation of 43 classrooms without fire safety clearance.

The Government has asked the school to submit its reply within seven days, failing which it may initiate proceedings to take over the management of the institution under Section 20 of the Delhi School Education Act, 1973, according to a statement.

It said the inspection found that the school was operating 82 classrooms despite having a fire No-Objection Certificate (NOC) for only 39 rooms. It alleged that 43 classrooms were functioning without fire safety clearance.

The inspection also allegedly found unauthorised tin-shed structures comprising 30 rooms, an illegal basement and an unauthorised third floor on the campus.

According to the state-

ment, some classrooms had only one exit door, while the passage meant for fire engines and emergency vehicles was blocked.

The DoE further alleged that the school was operating an unauthorised borewell, running senior secondary classes despite the expiry of its provisional recognition on March 31, 2023, increasing fees without the department's approval, delaying salaries of teachers, and paying them below Government-prescribed scales.

Education Minister Ashish Sood said the Government would not compromise on the safety of students and would take strict action wherever violations were found. "The Government has zero tolerance for any compromise on the safety of children. If an institution violates safety norms and other legal provisions, appropriate action will be taken to protect the interests of students," he said.

The Directorate of Education has also proposed recommending to the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) the cancellation of the lease of the land allotted to the school, the statement said



IN FOCUS



A woman carrying a child amid rainfall in Kolkata, West Bengal

PTI

Delhi reports most polluted July in 7 years

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi rounded off July with a month of weather contrasts, recording its most polluted July in seven years despite witnessing the month's first "good" air quality day in nearly a decade, above-normal monsoon rainfall fuelled by a few intense spells after a prolonged dry phase, and the warmest average day and night temperatures in two years.

The city's average Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 119 during the first 30 days of July, making it the highest monthly average for the month since 2019, when it was 134, according to an analysis by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA). The average was significantly higher than last July's monthly average of 78.

Even as the monthly average deteriorated, Delhi recorded its first "good" air quality day in July in nine years, with the AQI dropping to 48. It was the lowest daily minimum AQI recorded in July



since 2017, when the index had fallen to 43.

At the other end of the spectrum, the AQI climbed to 261 during the month, making it the highest daily maximum AQI recorded in July in five years, since 2021 when it was at 266. Rainfall during the month remained above normal at most weather stations despite a prolonged break in monsoon activity.

At the Safdarjung observatory, the city's base station, 254.7 mm of rainfall was recorded during July against the normal of 201.9 mm, an

excess of 52.8 mm or 26 per cent. Since the onset of the southwest monsoon, Safdarjung has recorded 296.5 mm of rainfall against the seasonal normal of 276 mm, a surplus of 20.5 mm or 7 per cent.

The Ridge observatory recorded the highest rainfall surplus among the major stations in July. The station received 285.5 mm of rainfall against the normal of 188.5 mm, an excess of 97 mm or 51 per cent. Since the onset of the monsoon, it has recorded 338.1 mm against the seasonal normal of

249.2 mm, a surplus of 88.9 mm or 36 per cent. Lodhi Road received 274.4 mm of rainfall during July against the normal of 201.9 mm, recording an excess of 72.5 mm or 36 per cent. Since June 1, the station has recorded 315.1 mm against the seasonal normal of 276 mm, a surplus of 39.1 mm or 14 per cent.

Ayanagar recorded 210.1 mm of rainfall during July against the normal of 178.5 mm, an excess of 31.6 mm or 18 per cent. Since the beginning of the southwest monsoon, the station has received 303.1 mm against the seasonal normal of 248.4 mm, a surplus of 54.7 mm or 22 per cent.

In contrast, Palam remained below normal. The station recorded 179.1 mm of rainfall during July against the normal of 198.2 mm, a deficit of 19.1 mm or 10 per cent. Since the onset of the southwest monsoon, it has received 229.4 mm against the seasonal normal of 267 mm, leaving it 37.6 mm below normal or 14 per cent in deficit.

Mahesh Palawat at Skymet Weather said the above-normal

rainfall despite fewer rainy days was due to an unusually long break in the monsoon.

"The monsoon witnessed a typical break this season, but instead of lasting five to six days as it usually does, it extended to around 10 to 11 days. As a result, the number of rainy days was lower, though the overall rainfall remained high because a few spells were particularly intense. The first few days of July saw very good monsoon activity, and the last week of the month remained active. In between, there was a prolonged break caused by multiple weather systems, which later triggered episodes of intense rainfall," he said.

The city also recorded its warmest July in terms of average day and night temperatures in two years. The average maximum temperature stood at 35.4 degrees Celsius and the average minimum at 27.7 degrees Celsius. The last time both averages were higher was in 2024, when the average maximum was 35.9 degrees Celsius, and the average minimum was 27.8 degrees Celsius.

100 versus 1: CM Yogi extensively covers over 100 constituencies in two months

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

With the Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections only a few months away, Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has markedly intensified his comprehensive public outreach and series of public engagements. Within a mere span of two months, the Chief Minister has successfully reached more than one hundred assembly constituencies.

Over the course of the preceding two months, CM Yogi Adityanath has undertaken extensive tours of all eighteen divisions of the state. During these visits, he has meticulously reviewed ongoing development works, conferred fresh developmental initiatives upon the regions, and forged direct connections with the citizenry through a succession of public assemblies.

In a remarkably concise period of just forty-five days, CM Yogi Adityanath has comprehensively traversed territories stretching from the eastern to the western extremities of the state, encompassing Bundelkhand.

His itinerary has encompassed visits to Bijnor, Ghaziabad, Agra, Jhansi, Mainpuri, Varanasi



Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath holds a mace during the inauguration and foundation stone laying of 268 public welfare projects in Ghazipur district

PTI

and Gorakhpur.

The Chief Minister's dynamic presence extends well beyond the sphere of public rallies. Whether it be party programmes, interactions with various delegations, reviews of law and order, or the daily conduct of Governmental affairs, CM Yogi Adityanath remains steadfastly active on every front. Concurrently, through the institution of public audiences, he continues to sustain direct dialogue with ordinary citizens. In this manner, his engagement stands firmly established across the triad of Government, organisation and the public.

Akhilesh's last public rally in march 2025

By contrast, Samajwadi Party leader Akhilesh Yadav held his most recent public rally in March 2026 at Dadri — an occasion widely regarded as the formal commencement of the party's campaign for the 2027 elections. Nearly four months have since elapsed, yet no subsequent major public rally has been convened by him. His activities appear largely confined to press conferences, social media platforms and the private

programmes of party leaders.

The pronounced '100 versus 1' distinction

When assessed in terms of public rallies, a clear and pronounced distinction of '100 versus 1' stands evident between CM Yogi Adityanath and Akhilesh Yadav. It is precisely this sustained ground-level activism of the Chief Minister that has ensured his popularity remains largely unaffected even after two successive terms of governance.

Mayawati's last significant rally occurred in October

The last major public rally organised by Bahujan Samaj Party supremo Mayawati in Uttar Pradesh was held on 9 October 2025 at the Kanshi Ram Memorial site in Lucknow.

Despite the approaching elections, the BSP continues to display the least degree of ground-level activity when compared with the Bharatiya Janata Party and the Samajwadi Party.

The greater part of Mayawati's communications is disseminated primarily through her social media platforms.

HC reserves order on Goa Govt's appeal against Tarun Tejpal's acquittal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

The Bombay High Court on Thursday reserved its order on the Goa Government's appeal against the acquittal of journalist Tarun Tejpal in a 2013 sexual assault case.

Justices Dr Neela Gokhale and Amit Jamsandekar of the Goa bench reserved the order after hearing arguments from both sides which mainly dwelt on whether the former Tehelka editor's "apology email" to the complainant amounted to an admission of guilt.

SC refuses ban on pellet guns, seeks...

Observing that police, as per the Bureau of Police Research and Development (BPRD) advisory, are empowered to use pellet guns in exceptional situations, a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana termed the prayer in the plea seeking a complete ban on such usage as vague.

"Prayers are not to use pellet guns. In exceptional cases, police regulations permit the use of pellet guns. If you are interested in phasing out pellet guns, you will have to challenge that very provision as ultra vires to Article 21 (right to life)," Justice Bagchi said.

The bench took note of the submissions of senior advocate Vrinda Grover, appearing for the petitioners, and asked the Delhi Government to provide the best treatment to Prashant Kumar, Sheikh Irshad Mansoori and others who suffered pellet gun injuries during the July 20 protest here. "I am not saying pellet guns should not be in the armoury of the RAF or not. Here it is different. They have used metallic pellets," she said. Grover said metal pellets were recovered from their bodies.

The bench said it was not averse to examining the use of pellets in a particular incident and the petitioners must show if it was permissible under a "graded approach". The senior lawyer said she was confining her reliefs to metallic pellets. Solicitor General Tushar Mehta said the Government will do whatever is necessary to assist the bench. Grover said the top court on July 28 directed the preservation of CCTV, drone and body camera footage and wireless logs, and did not specifically refer to the ammunition logs of the RAF. "Whatever is required for investigation will be preserved," the solicitor general said. According to the petition, the RAF, deployed to assist the Delhi Police in crowd management during the protests, resorted to tear gas, lathi-charge and subsequently fired pump-action guns loaded with metallic pellets near onnaught Place. The petitioners alleged that no prior warning or announcement was issued before the escalation in the use of force and that several protesters suffered serious injuries, including eye injuries.

Parliament clears anti-paper leak law

The BJP raised a strong protest against Kharge's remarks.

He alleged the Bill to amend the law to deal with exam paper leaks had been introduced mainly to defuse the charged atmosphere and pacify students and young people who had taken to the streets.

Kharge said the Government has not explained how it would conduct examinations that could prevent paper leaks. He said that provisions for higher fines, stricter punishment, and fast-track

courts would not make any difference in cases of paper leaks. What would make a difference, he argued, is how the Government conducts these examinations.

There was also an uproar in the House after Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge's remarks on Manusmriti. The slugfest started when Kharge referred to the Manusmriti, saying its elements were entering the school syllabi. He said, it teaches that if a Shudra (untouchable) listens to the Ved, "his ears should be filled with shards," if he reads the Ved aloud, "his tongue should be cut off," and if he retains its words "his body should be dismembered".

His comments drew strong objections and sloganeering from the treasury benches, and Nadda demanded the quotes be authenticated. The Rajya Sabha Chairperson asked what the Manusmriti had to do with the Bill. Nadda said the remarks on Manusmriti would create unrest and asked that only the original text be quoted in the House. Nadda had earlier asked Kharge not to use unparliamentary words.

Kharge also alleged that people associated with the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) were heading educational institutions and demanded their removal. He also criticised Union Minister of Home Affairs, Amit Shah for police brutality against the protestors at the Jantar Mantar last week. His remarks triggered strong objections from the treasury benches.

Only 34% vote as Kishor makes electoral debut

The BJP is hoping to retain the seat vacated by its national president Nitin Nabin. Earlier in the day, Kishor alleged that the police had wrongfully picked up his supporters at the behest of the ruling party, and the BJP charged the former poll strategist with having brought in "fake voters".

The Jan Suraj Party founder who stormed a police station in Patna late Wednesday evening, staying put till the early hours of Thursday, accused the police of acting as an "extension of a political party" and "trying to help the BJP" by detaining his party workers and "obstructing its voters".

"More than 16 Jan Suraj workers were detained by the police between Wednesday evening and night. They were kept at different police stations without specifying any reason, and then shifted to Danapur police station before being taken to the Shahpur PS," he said. Mritunjay Tiwari, who was recently inducted into the BJP after resigning from the RJD, alleged that Jan Suraj workers were trying to bring fake voters to Bankipur.

"The BJP has requested ECI officials to verify and inspect voter identities, so that people can exercise their democratic right to vote freely, fairly, and transparently," he said.

Tiwari claimed that Jan Suraj's strategy of using "fake voters" would not work, and Kishor's "security deposits will be forfeited".

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Talking to reporters outside a polling booth near Patna's Gol Ghar where Kishor and his party colleagues had a heated exchange with City SP (Central) Mamta Kalyani, the Jan Suraj founder alleged that his polling agents were being detained by the police.

Kalyani repudiated the allegations, saying, "Everyone has the right to vote. No one is being obstructed. We are making a continuous appeal that everyone should come and vote, but not form groups because that violates election protocols." BJP and Jan Suraj workers engaged in a mild altercation in the Shrikrishnapuri area within the assembly segment, but were pacified by the police.

Prominent politicians who voted in the assembly segment that covers a major part of the state capital include local BJP MP Ravishankar Prasad, senior party leader CP Thakur, his son and Nawada MP Vivek Thakur, and state ministers Ramkripal Yadav (BJP) and Ashok Choudhary (JDU). JD(U) president and former chief minister Nitish Kumar's elder sister Usha Devi and Neeraj Kumar Sinha, the BJP candidate, also voted. In a post on X, Nabin, who gave up the seat in April upon election to the Rajya Sabha, barely six months after having won it for a fifth consecutive term, had urged voters to come out in large numbers and "strengthen the resolve for a developed India".

According to a statement issued by the Patna SSP office, several individuals were taken into preventive custody because they, being non-resident campaigners of Bankipur, had not left the constituency during the 48-hour silence period, as mandated under ECI's directives.

The police, however, did not disclose the identity of the detainees, nor did they specify if they were Jan Suraj campaigners. Kishor claimed that around 10 of the detained Jan Suraj workers were from Patna district and not outsiders.

Parliament criminalises insults to...

Responding to a brief debate in the lower house, in which only two members participated, Minister of State for Home Affairs, Nityananda Rai said the Congress should have given Vande Mataram its due respect during its 76 years of rule, but instead it resorted to appeasement politics.

"For *Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat*, we need complete (all six stanzas) Vande Mataram song," Rai said, as he concluded his brief reply to the Bill with a chant of Vande Mataram.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour Act now prohibits intentionally preventing the singing of the national anthem and the national song, or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in such singing. These offences are punishable with imprisonment up to three years, a fine or both. A second and every subsequent conviction is punishable with imprisonment of a minimum of one year.

After the passage of the Bill, Lok Sabha was adjourned for the day.

Delhi eases NEET protest cases

According to the Delhi Police, several protesters attempted to breach barricades at multiple locations in New Delhi district during the march, triggering clashes with security personnel. While over 65 protesters were hurt in the violence, Delhi police claims, around 200 of its personnel were injured and that over 15 vehicles were damaged during the protest. The Delhi Police had also registered FIR at the Special Cell police station against social media handles for allegedly using derogatory remarks against the prime minister. Police officials said that they have identified such people using facial recognition system (FRS) high resolution camera installed at the Jantar Mantar. Following the clashes, Delhi Police detained several protesters. Senior officers later clarified that all the detained were released.

E20 can cut mileage: Gadkari

Meanwhile, Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri met representatives of Team Bharat, an outfit that is spearheading the protests against the alleged rushed implementation of E20 petrol on July 31.

Critics have questioned whether all vehicles are fully compatible with E20, flagged the possibility of reduced fuel efficiency and higher maintenance costs, and sought clarity on liability if engine or fuel-system problems arise.

Gadkari in his written reply claimed that ethanol blended petrol programme commenced with a pilot in 2001, E5 was introduced in 2006, and although blending remained around 1.53 per cent in 2013-14, it has since been increased progressively in a calibrated manner after creating the necessary production capacity, infrastructure and regulatory framework.

The minister explained that the Ethanol blended petrol (EBP) programme has been implemented through a phased, scientifically validated and consultative process involving NITI Aayog, automobile manufacturers, Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs), Automotive Research Association of India (ARAI), Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM), Indian Institute of Petroleum (IIP) and other technical institutions. According to him, E15+ blended petrol has been in widespread use for over three-and-a-half years and E19-E20 fuel for over two-and-a-half years.

"Manufacturer service data confirm that there is no abnormal corrosion, wear or reduction in vehicle life due to E20 fuel," he said, adding that manufacturers continue to honour warranty obligations for vehicles using E20 fuel, providing further confidence in its safety and reliability.

PM reviews global risks in CCS meet

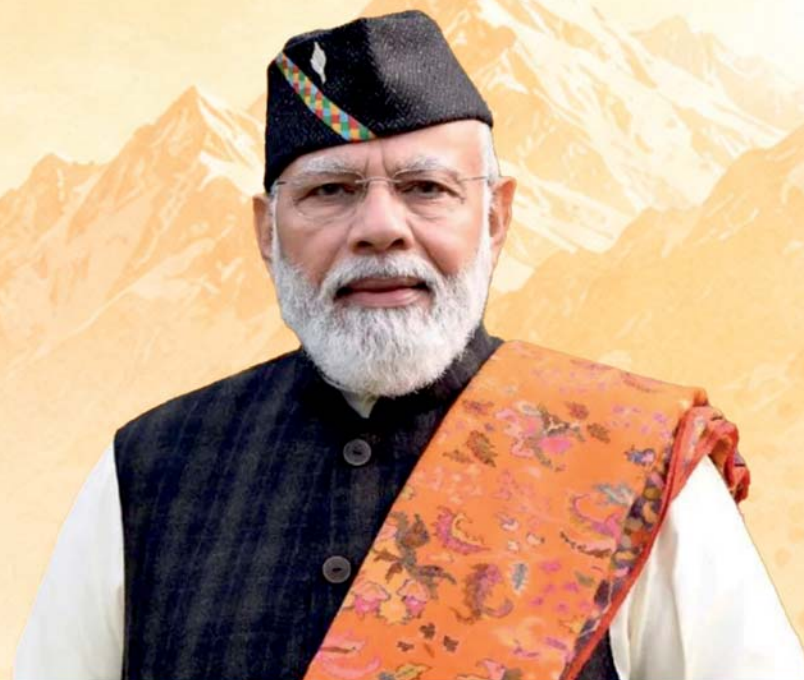
According to sources, the discussions covered the security implications of multiple ongoing conflicts and the resulting disruptions to India's imports, a large share of which transit through these volatile zones. Ministers made detailed presentations on the steps already taken by their respective ministries to ensure uninterrupted inflow of essential commodities, particularly petroleum, natural gas and fertilisers.

The safety of Indian citizens living and working in conflict zones and the protection of Indian seafarers were reviewed at length. Nearly one crore Indians reside and work in West Asia, making their security a key concern. The Prime Minister is learnt to have issued specific directions to the ministers to prioritise the safety of Indians abroad, protect the country's economic interests, and explore alternative routes and mechanisms to overcome supply-chain bottlenecks. India depends on imports to meet more than 88 per cent of its energy requirements and also sources a significant volume of fertilisers from overseas.

Prior to the escalation involving the United States, Israel and Iran, roughly 40 per cent of India's energy imports passed through the Strait of Hormuz. With the conflict remaining unresolved, energy shipments from West Asia have been severely affected. Imports through the strait continue to remain minimal because of intermittent attacks on oil and cargo vessels. In the Red Sea-Gulf of Aden region, the Yemen-based Houthi group last week declared that it would target Saudi Arabian tankers attempting to transit the Bab al-Mandab Strait.

The group has since attacked several ships. The Bab al-Mandab, which links the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Arabian Sea, is a critical global chokepoint for trade and energy supplies, comparable in strategic importance to the Strait of Hormuz. Available data show that average daily ship crossings through the Bab al-Mandab have already fallen to 31 over the past three days, down from 43 in the first half of July.

Russian oil imports via the Black Sea are also under pressure as the Russia-Ukraine conflict intensifies, with several recent attacks reported on vessels operating in those waters. The meeting reflected the Government's assessment that geopolitical tensions in these maritime corridors pose both immediate security challenges and longer-term risks to India's energy security, food security and overall economic stability. Sources said that the CCS looked at the global political situation as a whole, while focusing on practical ways to keep supply lines open and protect Indian interests. The long CCS discussions show that New Delhi is taking a proactive approach to handling outside challenges in a world where shipping routes are often disrupted.



“ Hon'ble Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi Ji has called the third decade of the 21st century the decade of Uttarakhand. In line with the Prime Minister's vision, we are working with a 'resolve without alternative' (Vikalp Rahit Sankalp) to make the state an ideal state in every field. ”

Pushkar Singh Dhami
Chief Minister, Uttarakhand

Viksit Bharat Sashakt Uttarakhand

“ The construction of a developed India in the 21st century rests on two main pillars: first, pride in our heritage, and second, making every possible effort for development. Today, Uttarakhand is continuously strengthening both these pillars. This decade is the decade of Uttarakhand. ”

Narendra Modi
Prime Minister



Sewa - Sushasan - Samarpan

Employment

- Strict Anti-Copying/Anti-Cheating Law & Transparent Recruitment Process: Selection across multiple departments 33,000 youths given government jobs in the past 5 years.
- Chief Minister Skill Upgradation & Global Employment Scheme: Budget increased from ₹75 lakh to ₹33 crore; foreign language training provided to 147 children, with 92 securing employment abroad.
- Growth in MSME Employment: Number of people employed in MSMEs increased from 3,43,922 in 2022 to 4,56,605 in 2025.
- 10% Horizontal Reservation for Agniveers: Applicable to direct recruitment in Group 'C' uniformed services in government jobs.
- Devbhoomi Entrepreneurship Development Scheme: 300+ students established enterprises, registration of nearly 1,200 students is underway, and employment generated for 1,541 students and others.

Industries

- New Momentum to Development Through Grounding of Investments Worth Over ₹1.00 Lakh Crore.
- Investment Agreements Worth ₹3.56 Lakh Crore: Signed during the Global Investors Summit.
- Expansion of Land Bank: Over 6,000 acres of additional land bank developed for industries.
- Thriving MSME Sector: Over 96,400 MSME units active across the state.
- Massive Job Creation in MSME: Generated over 4.70 lakh jobs in the MSME sector.
- Flourishing Startup Culture: Over 1,750 startups established in the state.
- National Recognition: Uttarakhand recognized as a "Leader" state in the States' Startup Ecosystem Ranking.
- Large-Scale Industries: 128 large industrial units currently operational in the state.

Education

- Uttarakhand has become the first state in the country to implement the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020.
- Under the PM SHRI Scheme, 141 schools were selected in the first phase and 84 schools in the second phase.
- Virtual classrooms are being operated in 500 Government Secondary Schools across the state.
- The total number of Government and Private Degree Colleges in the state increased to 139 by 2025.
- The total number of Engineering Colleges (Government and Private) in the state increased to 52 by 2025.
- Under the Secondary Education programme, free textbooks are being provided to students of Class I to XII studying in Government and Private schools across the state.

Health

- Construction of the AIIMS Satellite Centre at Kichha is underway, with 85% of the work completed.
- The AIIMS Kichha project includes a 250-bed hospital, 10 Operation Theatres (OTs), 30 ICU beds, advanced Diagnostics & Laboratory facilities, and speciality departments including Cardiology, Nephrology, Urology, Neurology, General Surgery, Orthopaedics, General Medicine, Paediatrics, and an Emergency & Trauma Centre.
- More than 6.1 million Ayushman Cards have been issued across the state under the Atal Ayushman Yojana.
- Under the Atal Ayushman Yojana, more than 1.7 million patients have received cashless treatment worth over ₹3,400 crore.
- 207 types of pathology tests are being provided completely free of cost across the state.
- A target has been set to establish a Medical College in every district. At present, five Medical Colleges are operational, while two more are under construction.
- Super-speciality healthcare services are available at the Medical Colleges in Dehradun, Haldwani, and Srinagar.
- The newly constructed Child and Mother Care Hospital in Haridwar is now operational.



Connectivity

- Inauguration of the 210-km Delhi–Dehradun Economic Corridor, featuring Asia's longest 12-km Wildlife Corridor.
- The Rishikesh–Karnaprayag Rail Project is progressing at a rapid pace.
- The state's road network has expanded to 51,728 km.
- The All Weather Road Project has ensured seamless connectivity to the Char Dham shrines and border areas.
- A new terminal has been developed at Dehradun Airport, with regular flight connectivity to major cities across the country.
- 13 new heliports are currently under construction.
- Construction of the Sonprayag–Kedarnath (12.9 km) and Govindghat–Hemkund Sahib (12.4 km) Ropeway Projects has commenced.

Women Empowerment

- 30% horizontal reservation has been implemented for women in Government jobs across the state.
- 33% reservation for women has been ensured in Co-operative Management Committees.
- Under the Chief Minister Self-Help Group Empowerment Scheme, Self-Help Groups are provided interest-free loans of up to ₹5 lakh.
- Under the Lakhpati Didi Scheme, more than 2.54 lakh women in the state have become Lakhpati Didis.
- Under the Chief Minister Mahalakshmi Kit Scheme, women are provided with essential maternity kits after childbirth.
- Under the Nanda Gaura Scheme, the State Government provides ₹11,000 on the birth of a girl child and ₹51,000 for higher education after she passes Class XII.

Youth Welfare

- Under the New Sports Policy, a historic decision has been taken to provide Government jobs to medal winners at the National and International levels.
- The daily diet allowance for sportspersons has been increased from ₹250 to ₹480 per athlete per day, in line with the Sports Authority of India (SAI).
- Under the Chief Minister Emerging Sportsperson Development Scheme, around 3,900 emerging athletes aged 8 to 14 years are being provided a monthly sports scholarship of ₹1,500.
- Sportspersons who have won medals or represented the country at National and International events such as the Olympic Games, Asian Games, Commonwealth Games, etc., will receive the benefit of the 4% Sports Quota in Government Services.
- 60 Patent Information Centres have been established in various colleges, universities, and other institutions across the state.

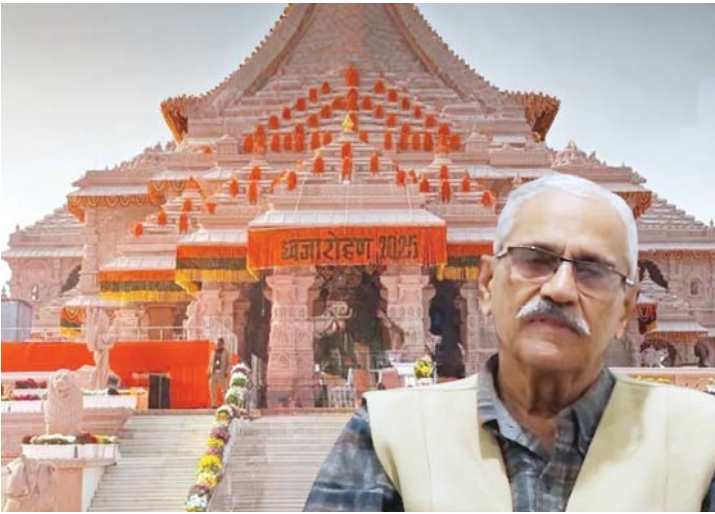
Ram Mandir trust to appoint Jagdish Aafle as first secretary

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust is all set to name Jagdish Aafle as its first secretary. Aafle has overseen the Ram Mandir project for several years and is associated with the RSS. The executive committee will consider his nomination for approval at its meeting on September 2, according to sources at the temple.

Aafle, who is from Pune, brings both technical expertise and commitment to the project. He has a BTech in Electrical Engineering and an MTech from IIT Bombay. After working in India, Europe, and the United States, he returned to India upon retirement. He became the honorary project manager for the Ram Mandir on the RSS's recommendation when construction started in 2020.

Since then, he and his wife have lived at the temple site in Ayodhya, overseeing important parts of the construction. The Ram Mandir is making big changes, including



adding a new secretary position. Interim General Secretary Krishna Mohan has confirmed that Aafle has been nominated for the job. If the committee approves, the appointment will be announced after the September 2 meeting. The trust is also choosing a new spokesperson from several candidates. These

changes come after the trust recently faced some challenges.

After allegations of cash donation misuse, the Uttar Pradesh Government set up a Special Investigation Team (SIT) in June 2026. As a result, former General Secretary Champat Rai, who was also the spokesperson, and trustee

Anil Mishra resigned. The trust formed an interim panel with Krishna Mohan, Aafle, and chartered accountant Chandan Rai to manage banking and restore financial oversight. Now that Aafle is an authorised signatory for the trust's State Bank of India accounts, payments like staff salaries have started again.

The September 2 meeting will address several unresolved issues. At the July 22 meeting, the trust delayed choosing a permanent general secretary and its first Chief Executive Officer (CEO), saying they needed more time. More than 5,200 people have applied for the CEO job, which is meant to bring professional management to the temple complex that serves millions of devotees every year.

A nine-member religious committee now oversees rituals and spiritual practices. The Government of India set up the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust in February 2020 after the Supreme Court decided on the Ram Janmabhoomi site. The trust is

responsible for building and managing the temple. The pran pratishtha ceremony on January 22, 2024, was a historic event for the temple. Under Chairman Mahant Nrityagopal Das, the trust has moved from construction to full operational management of one of Hinduism's main pilgrimage sites. Aafle's promotion from honorary project manager to secretary shows the trust values continuity and experience. His long involvement and RSS background have prepared him for more administrative duties, such as working with the religious committee, managing finances, and overseeing security.

With the CEO selection ongoing and trustee positions under review, the September 2 meeting will be important for deciding the trust's leadership. As the Ram Mandir enters a new phase of management, Aafle's appointment is expected to bring careful planning and dedicated service to the secretariat. This should help make operations more efficient and support the temple's spiritual goals.

Govt, Meta to discuss PM Modi's Facebook post restriction



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A brief restriction on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Facebook post has stirred concern in the government, which will hold discussions with Meta within a week on policy and technical matters linked to the incident.

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of the CII conference on semiconductors, Electronics and IT Secretary S Krishnan said that the Government has asked Meta to come in at the highest level and explain the issue that led to the glitch.

"They will be coming and explaining what the situation is. We want to have both a policy-level and a technical understanding of the issues, and an adaptation to the kinds of concerns India has in this regard. There are several issues we have, which we will raise with them when they come. I think, within the next week, they will be coming," he said.

The Government has summoned Meta's public policy head after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's Facebook post, on July 23, addressing India's youth and promising stringent measures against exam paper leaks, was briefly restricted by the US-head-

quartered social media giant. The move assumes significance as the Government on Tuesday summoned a top Meta executive after Modi's recent post addressing India's youth and promising stringent measures against paper leaks was briefly restricted on Facebook.

Meta, the owner of social media platform Facebook, is learnt to have written to the Government outlining the specifics of enhanced and rigorous safeguards it has now implemented for content posted by Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other prominent accounts.

While the social media giant attributed the incident to a technical glitch and apologised, the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) found the explanation "inadequate".

Meta has now informed the ministry that posts by the Prime Minister and select prominent accounts will be subject to additional oversight on the platform, with multiple levels of checks involving senior company officials, sources said. Any decision will undergo rigorous checks and require review by at least two senior officials of the company, sources said, citing the social media firm's latest communication to the ministry.

West Bengal Govt to include eggs in school mid-day meals



SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Bengal Government has decided to introduce eggs, slightly amending its earlier decision to serve "Satvik" midday meals in Government schools in Kolkata through the International Society of Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON).

While ISKCON, a purely vegetarian institution, will provide only the cooked meals, the State Government will get the eggs served through other NGOs.

The State Government decision comes following criticism from certain sections over discontinuing eggs — a key source of protein — in midday meals, which was a normal practice.

Referring to the new development, Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari said, "From August 1, a pilot project will be launched in most schools in Kolkata...

ISKCON will provide pure satvik, protein-rich meals... In addition, eggs will be distributed separately through self-help groups so that children can receive a protein-rich food."

The decision reportedly comes close on the heels of a social media video where a Class II girl was seen sneaking an egg provided in the midday meal into her pocket. When questioned about what she was doing she told the teachers that she wanted to take the egg back home for her infant brother, who too loved eggs.

Earlier, the Opposition parties had opposed the Government decision to introduce ISKCON-made foods "in a bid to change the food habits of the children... not only fiddling with local culture but also depriving the young children of a rich source of protein... as also robbing the school sevikas of their jobs to prepare meals."

Mamata faction may soon move SC claiming TMC leadership

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

The Mamata Banerjee faction of the Trinamool Congress could soon move the Supreme Court claiming leadership of the party witnessing a fratricidal battle ever since it lost power in this year's Assembly elections. Sources close to senior advocate and pro-Mamata Banerjee MP Kalyan Banerjee said, quoting the leader, "Expect something new and big next week."

He was referring to an appeal earlier made by the former Bengal Chief Minister to the Election Commission of India to hasten up the process of inquiry into the leadership issue in the TMC. The TMC MP is known to

have reasoned with the party chief about the efficacy of knocking the Apex Court doors when the time was opportune. However, sources would not make it clear whether the party has taken a final decision on the matter.

On whether the party had immediately taken Kalyan Banerjee's advice to move the Supreme Court — considering his not-so-good chemistry with general secretary Abhishek Banerjee — is not known, but sources said Mamata Banerjee was not averse to the idea of moving the Apex Court.

The development comes in tandem with Mamata Banerjee writing on Wednesday a letter to ECI Secretary Ashwani Kumar Mohal requesting the



authorities to "conclude the investigation as early as possible without providing them with any further date to submit their comments." This, because "the matter has serious political ramifications" in Bengal.

"I would request you to conclude the investigation as early as possible without providing them with any further date to submit their comments," she wrote.

While 20 party MPs led by

Kakoli Ghoshdastidar had defected and joined a little-known Nationalist Citizens Party of India (NCPI) soon after the elections, about 60 out of 80 rebel MLAs led by present Opposition Leader Ritabrata Banerjee had carved out a separate group demanding ownership of the State party on account of their numerical majority. The matter has been pending with the ECI.

"We firmly believe that because of the extension of time granted by you, Shri Ritabrata Banerjee and others are trying to create false evidence to develop their case since they do not have any merit in respect of their allegations which we have firmly disputed," she wrote.

CBI brings fugitive back from Fiji accused in multi-crore investment scheme case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), working with the Ministry of External Affairs, the Ministry of Home Affairs, and Maharashtra Police, helped bring Rahul Shamrao Kalokhe back from Fiji after an Interpol Red Notice was issued.

Kalokhe is accused of being part of a large investment fraud. The CBI says he and his associates promised investors very high and guaranteed returns, which led people to invest large amounts. The money was then used for personal gain. Kalokhe left India to avoid investigation and prosecution. At the request of the Maharashtra Police, the CBI obtained an Interpol Red Notice. He was found in Fiji, held by local authorities, and sent back to

India after the required steps were completed.

Public records show Rahul Shamrao Kalokhe (DIN 09677296) is a director of Trdez Investment Private Limited, started in July 2022 in Pune, Maharashtra (CIN U65993PN2022PTC213159), and Infinite Beacon India Private Limited, started in July 2023. He owns a large share in Trdez along with other directors, including Prasad Prakashrao Kulkarni.

In April 2026, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) took action against Trdez Investment. SEBI found that the company's stock-broking licence was used to give false regulatory legitimacy to several companies, including Infinite Beacon, IB Prop Desk, and Sispay TFS. Together, these companies raised over ₹2,950 crore from the public by promising

monthly returns of 10 to 12 per cent. Agents used Trdez's SEBI registration to build trust with investors, but the money was sent to related companies instead of the broker. SEBI found that only about ₹43,430 in proprietary trades had been recorded, and there were no client trades since the company began.

Directors and associates set up partnership firms to collect money from the public. Investors saw dashboards showing fake profits, and some early withdrawals were allowed to build trust before restrictions were put in place. Some funds were reportedly sent to cryptocurrencies like USDT. Even after complaints, Trdez only gave general disclaimers and did not take real action. SEBI fined Trdez ₹1 crore for breaking the stock-broker code of conduct and SEBI Act rules. In



March 2026, stock exchanges such as BSE, NSE, and MCX removed Trdez Investment as a trading member.

SEBI's investigation also found that contact details for Infinite Beacon Financial Services were linked to Kalokhe's phone number and email address. Earlier reports

Congress wants to spread negativity around Hindu dharma: BJP on Priyanka's gau mutra expert remark

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP slammed the Congress on Thursday over Priyanka Gandhi Vadra's "gau mutra expert" remark against IIT Madras Director V Kamakoti, alleging that the main opposition party wants to spread negativity about Indian culture and Hindu dharma.

Participating in a discussion in the Lok Sabha on "The Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill 2026" on Tuesday, Priyanka Gandhi launched a stinging attack on the Government over the lathi-charge on protesting students. She said Prime Minister Narendra Modi needs to change his "dil ka angle" instead of camera angles if he wants to win over Gen Z. She also suggested that the prime minister should change his advisors because he has become far removed from reality.

"He needs to understand that merely setting up new committees will not work. Not a single recommendation of the Radhakrishnan Committee has been implemented to date. Meanwhile, the new committee includes a former IB chief, an IT company owner, and even a 'gau mutra' expert," the Wayanad MP said.



Hitting back, BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi said this demonstrated the negativity the Congress "wish to spread regarding Indian culture and Hinduism".

"These people who talk about the RSS. We lost access to so many sources of our knowledge because of them as they remained 'and-hbhakt' (blind devotees) of the West since the Nehru era," the BJP Rajya Sabha MP told reporters in the Parliament House complex.

Trivedi said the Congress must know that there is a patent for 'Gau Mutra' in the US recognising its anti-bacterial and anti-fungal medicinal properties.

"If their (Congress leaders') minds hadn't been filled with the 'gobar' (rubbish) of Macaulay and Marx and if they had instead been grounded in the values of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh, we wouldn't have had to go all

the way to the US to fight for patents for turmeric, neem, and tulsi," he said.

The Congress leaders must introspect and accept that they were far away from 'bharatiyata' (Indianness), Trivedi said. Kamakoti, a Padma awardee, is a member of the six-member task force on exam reforms constituted by the Centre after the NEET paper leak row. He had courted controversy in January 2025 with his speech during Pongal celebrations at a cow shelter in Chennai.

In his speech, Kamakoti narrated the story of a 'sanyasi' who, according to him, recovered from high fever after drinking cow urine. A video of the speech went viral, drawing criticism from several scientists, politicians and social media users. Responding to the criticism, Kamakoti had maintained at the time that his comments were based on published scientific literature.

We want withdrawal of FIRs, not just closure: CJP's Saurav Das

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday welcomed the Delhi government's notification directing that no further action be taken on FIRs filed in connection with its 36-day agitation, but said the cases should be formally withdrawn, warning that any dilution of the assurances given under the July 25 Jantar Mantar agreement could force students back onto the streets.

Speaking to PTI Videos, CJP chief spokesperson Saurav Das said the wording of the notification did not reflect what was promised by the government.

"The Delhi Government has released a notification which says that all the FIRs will not be pursued further and they may be treated as closed. We are not very happy with the term. The term that they should have used is that the FIRs will be withdrawn," Das said.

Das said the order did not bar withdrawal of FIRs.

"The Government is saying that the Supreme Court has mandated that the FIRs proceed. But that's a misreading and a misleading of the situation. Nowhere in the Supreme Court order has the



Supreme Court said that the FIRs cannot be withdrawn. Those powers exist with the government," he said.

He urged the Centre to honour the assurances given to protesters on July 25.

"The Government should not be using the Supreme Court order as a weapon to go against protesters. What was guaranteed before the entire nation on July 25, the Jantar Mantar agreement, the Government should come good on its promises and honour its words," Das said.

"If it does not honour its words in letter and spirit, then the young generation of this country will never ever forgive them and will be forced to come back on the streets," Das said.

Das said the Delhi government's notification was a "positive development" but maintained that the commitments made to the protesters had to be implemented in full.

WOMAN BOOKED FOR PM REMARKS

Noida (UP): A Zero FIR has been registered in Noida against a woman for allegedly using abusive language against Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a protest at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi, police said on Thursday. The FIR was lodged at the Expressway police station on the complaint of Smriti Singh, a resident of Ghaziabad, against Ruchika Singh, a resident of Sector 168 in Noida.

According to the FIR, the complainant alleged that on July 23, the accused used "abusive and objectionable" language against the prime minister at Jantar Mantar, hurting the dignity of the constitutional office and with the intention of spreading hatred and disturbing public peace.

Based on the complaint, the police registered a case under Sections 352 (intentional insult to provoke breach of peace), 353(1) (statements conducing to public mischief) and 356(1) (defamation) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS), officials said. (PTI)

Final list for Karnataka Cabinet expansion soon: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Bangaluru

Karnataka's much-awaited cabinet expansion is now likely to take place on Monday, with the final list of ministers expected to be cleared by Sunday night or Monday morning, sources close to Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar said.

According to the sources, the decision was taken at a meeting held at Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge's residence in New Delhi on Thursday.

Congress MP Rahul Gandhi, Chief Minister DK Shivakumar, former chief minister Siddaramaiah, Congress general secretary KC Venugopal, AICC general secretary in charge of Karnataka Randeep Singh Surjewala and Congress Karnataka president BK Hariprasad attended the meeting.

Sources close to the chief minister said that the leadership discussed the probable candidates for induction into the cabinet, taking into account caste, religion and regional representation.

"It was decided that the list of the probable candidates will be cleared on Sunday night or by Monday morning. The cabinet expansion is now



likely to take place on Monday evening," the sources said.

The expansion had earlier been expected to take place on Friday, but the schedule has now been pushed back following the discussions in Delhi, they added.

The cabinet expansion has been under discussion for several weeks after Shivakumar assumed office as chief minister on June 3.

At present, Karnataka has 14 ministers, including the chief minister, against the permissible strength of 34, leaving 20 vacancies in the council of ministers.

With a large number of vacancies still to be filled, Congress legislators have intensified lobbying for a place in the ministry.

Sources said the party leadership is attempting to strike a balance among various social groups and regions while finalising the list of ministers.

CRPF DG assures full backing for force personnel on 88th Raising Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) Director General GP Singh has assured personnel of the country's largest paramilitary force that he would take "complete responsibility" for any decision or action taken by officers and jawans during the bona fide discharge of their duties.

At the 88th Raising Day event at CRPF headquarters, the Director General reiterated the leadership's commitment to support personnel operating in challenging environments.

"I will take complete responsibility for any decision and action undertaken by the officers and jawans during bona fide discharge of their duties," Singh said, according to officials present at the function.

The assurance was issued as CRPF units remain deployed in counter-insurgency operations in Jammu and Kashmir, Left-Wing Extremism-affected regions, and law and order duties in several states and established in 1939 as the Crown Representative's Police, the force now undertakes internal security, VIP protection, election duties, and disaster response.

Officials said the DG's statement was intended to boost morale among personnel, who often face complex



situations requiring immediate decisions under pressure. The leadership conveyed that actions taken in good faith would have institutional support, aiming to reduce concerns about later scrutiny or legal issues.

CRPF currently has a strength of over three lakh personnel and is the primary force for internal security duties. The CRPF has over three lakh personnel and serves as the primary force for internal security.

Its units are central to security during elections and large gatherings.

The force has also played a key role in anti-Naxal operations, contributing to a reduction in the spread of Left-Wing Extremism in the last decade. In difficult conditions. He reminded the personnel that the trust of

the public and the confidence of the Government rest on the force's ability to act with both firmness and fairness.

The assurance of complete responsibility for bona fide actions is particularly significant in the current operational context.

Security forces often face situations involving armed groups, stone-pelting, or sudden threats, where the use of force may later be scrutinised. The DG's statement indicated that leadership would support personnel in such cases.

The force's internal solidarity and a recognition of the risks they undertake daily. The DG also interacted with family members of personnel and acknowledged the sacrifices they make in supporting their

relatives serving in remote and high-risk postings.

Raising Day marks an opportunity for the CRPF to review its legacy and prepare for future challenges. The force has evolved from its colonial origins to its current role in internal security, now facing challenges such as insurgency, urban unrest, and rapid disaster response.

The Director General's remarks emphasised operational confidence, stating he would take responsibility for actions performed in good faith. This was intended to enable junior commanders and personnel to act decisively when required.

The event also featured cultural programmes and awards for gallantry and distinguished service. Recipients were felicitated for acts of bravery. The event included cultural programmes and awards for gallantry and distinguished service.

Personnel were recognised for acts of bravery in operational areas. The DG's statement on Monday sought to strike precisely that balance. With the force continuing to play a pivotal role in India's internal security, the headquarters conveyed that personnel serving with integrity and commitment will have leadership support.

NEET-UG 2026: Teachers became the weakest link

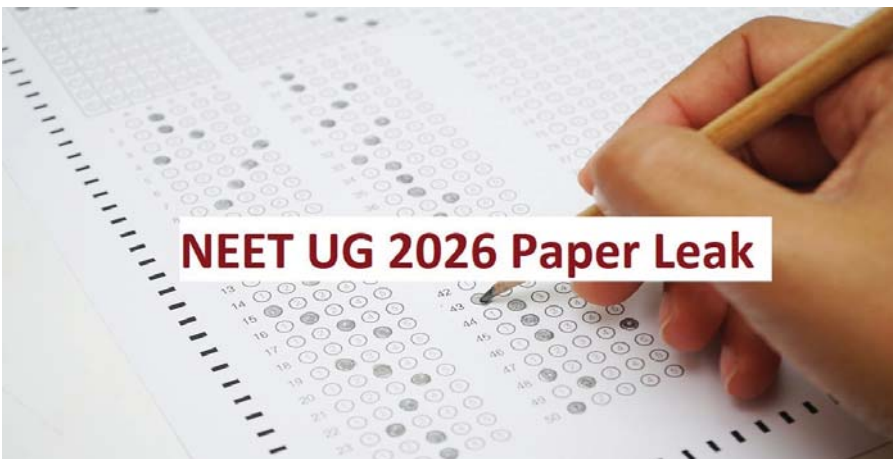
PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The National Testing Agency (NTA) tried to keep the NEET-UG examination secure, but the system failed because three teachers, trusted with both setting and translating the papers, quietly found a way in. According to sources close to the investigation, giving the same people both roles was the main weakness that led to the 2026 medical entrance test being compromised. In contrast to the open leak in 2024, when a centre-in-charge worked with a group to steal and share a real question paper, the 2026 problems were more subtle.

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) told the NTA to change how exams were transported, handled, and conducted. The NTA followed these suggestions. No physical paper was stolen in 2025 or 2026. Still, the exam was cancelled on May 12 when a candidate turned in a set of questions that matched the real ones.

The three subject experts on the NTA panel — chemistry teacher PV Kulkarni, physics teacher Manisha Gurunath Mandhare, and biology teacher Manisha Sanjay Havaladar — were responsible for both finalising the questions and translating them into Marathi.

The process took several days in a secure setting. Each evening, the teachers went home to Pune, taught their usual tuition classes,



and came back the next day. Investigators believe that during this time, they memorised the final version of the paper. Later, in their coaching classes, they recreated a question bank and marked some questions as "very important."

Students in a private group got these questions, but the teachers never said they were from the upcoming national exam.

This situation might have stayed local if not for Manisha Waghmare, a beautician who knew the teachers. She got the question bank from students, typed it up as a formal question paper, and sold it to Dhananjay Nivrutti Lokhande. From there, the material passed through several people in different states, with large sums of money involved.

If Waghmare had not been involved, the questions might not have reached so

many students, and the problem might have stayed hidden. Instead, one paper ended up with a candidate who reported it to the NTA.

The Union Ministry of Education handed over the case to the CBI, which acted quickly. Within days, the agency arrested 13 people, including the three teachers, Waghmare, Lokhande, coaching institute associates, and several intermediaries.

A chargesheet with all their names has been filed in a special court in New Delhi. Bank accounts, lockers, and a demat account connected to the accused have been frozen.

The CBI has informally conveyed to the NTA that allowing the same individuals to handle both setting and translation creates problems. The CBI has told the NTA that letting the same people set and translate the exam gave them too much access and time.

Formal recommendations are expected soon.

"This case shows a bigger problem in the system. Secure rooms and limited movement do not help if the experts can leave each night, teach, and come back. In the end, it is much harder to control what someone remembers than to lock up a trunk", sources added.

For the NTA, this shows that the procedural reforms made after 2024 only tackled the most obvious weaknesses. The human factor, such as trusted subject experts with multiple roles and free time in the evenings, was overlooked until three teachers, a beautician, and a group of intermediaries showed how easily it could be misused.

The agency, known for conducting one of India's most important exams, now has to face the uncomfortable fact that the biggest risk can sometimes come from inside the exam room itself.

Datia bypoll records 71.4% turnout, direct contest between BJP, Congress

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

The Datia Assembly byelection recorded a voter turnout of 71.4 per cent till the close of polling on Thursday, around nine percentage points lower than the 80.2 per cent turnout recorded in the 2023 Assembly election.

Polling remained largely peaceful despite sporadic technical glitches, rain-related disruptions and allegations of irregularities by the Congress. Counting of votes will take place on August 3.

The byelection witnessed a direct contest between BJP candidate Ashutosh Tiwari and Congress nominee Ghanshyam Singh, while Damodar Singh Yadav of the Azad Samaj Party was also in the fray along with 18 other candidates. A total of 291 polling stations were set up for the election, including 186 in rural areas and 105 in urban areas. The constituency has over 2.20 lakh registered voters.

Datia Collector and District Election Officer Swapnil Wankhede said polling commenced on schedule at all booths and adequate arrangements had been made to ensure free and fair voting. Minor technical glitches were reported in VVPAT, ballot and control units at a few polling stations, but officials said these were resolved without affecting the polling process.

The Congress alleged incidents of fake voting at polling stations in Sirol and Jigna, prompting candidate Ghanshyam Singh to visit the locations and raise the issue with election officials. The



party also accused the BJP of attempting booth capturing at Polling Booth No. 51. Singh alleged that one of his polling agents was taken away by police, while another BJP polling agent tried to influence the voting process before being removed by CRPF personnel. He demanded an impartial inquiry, claiming the entire incident was captured on CCTV.

Former Home Minister Narottam Mishra dismissed the allegations, saying the Congress routinely levels such charges whenever it anticipates defeat. State Congress President Jitu Patwari, however, claimed the party would register a comfortable victory despite the BJP deploying its full organisational strength.

Polling was briefly affected by waterlogging at a few booths due to rain, while residents of Lakhampur village initially boycotted voting over the lack of road connectivity before officials persuaded them to cast their votes.

The byelection was necessitated following the disqualification of former Congress MLA Rajendra Bharti after his conviction in a fraud case.

NGT orders Bhoj Wetland encroachments removed by August 31

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bhopal

The National Green Tribunal (NGT) has issued stringent directions to protect the ecologically sensitive Bhoj Wetland and remove encroachments within the 50-metre Full Tank Level (FTL) zone, reaffirming that environmental conservation must take precedence over unauthorised development.

Hearing four connected petitions related to Bhoj Wetland, Kaliyasot Dam, Kerwa Dam and the Bhopal lake system, the Tribunal directed the district administration to intensify action against illegal constructions and ensure strict compliance with wetland conservation norms. The applicant was represented by advocate Harshvardhan Tiwari.

The NGT observed that the matter extends beyond the removal of encroachments and concerns the scientific identification and demarca-

tion of wetland and FTL boundaries, prevention of untreated sewage from entering water bodies and long-term preservation of the region's ecological balance.

During the hearing, the administration informed the Tribunal that nine commercial encroachments had already been removed, while action against nine residential encroachments was pending as they were located in inhabited areas. In Prempura village, 35 encroachments were identified on Khasra No. 131, of which 23 have been cleared, reclaiming nearly one acre of Government land. The remaining 12 residential encroachments will be removed after alternative accommodation is provided to affected families under the Housing for All scheme.

A detailed survey of seven villages — Prempura, Dharampuri, Sevania Gond, Gaura, Bishankhedhi, Bilkhiria and Kotra Sultanabad — iden-



tified 117 encroachments within the 50-metre FTL zone. Of these, 68 were found on Government land and 49 on private land.

Authorities informed the Tribunal that 45 encroachments had been removed, while action against the remaining 72 was underway.

Questioning the persistence of illegal constructions despite repeated enforcement drives, the petitioner argued that fresh encroachments continue to emerge in environmentally sensitive areas, undermining earlier directions of the Tribunal.

The plea sought stricter, time-bound enforcement to safeguard the wetland ecosystem.

The Tribunal was also urged to ensure scientific demarcation of the boundaries of Bhoj Lake, Kaliyasot Dam and Kerwa Dam, regulate the use of chemical fertilisers and pesticides in surrounding agricultural areas to prevent water pollution, and protect the proposed 150-hectare botanical garden.

Appearing through video conferencing, TT Nagar SDM Archana Sharma informed the Tribunal that several encroachments in the FTL



During his Jharkhand visit, DG CRPF GP Singh, IPS, met and felicitated the brave personnel of 209 CoBRA at GC Ranchi for apprehending CPI (Maoist) Central Committee member Misir Besra

Haridwar braces for over 4 crore devotees as Kanwar Yatra starts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Haridwar

The Kanwar Yatra commenced on Thursday with the start of the holy month of Sawan, with over four crore devotees from across states expected to arrive in Haridwar and surrounding areas over the next fortnight to collect water from the holy Ganga, officials said.

During the annual pilgrimage, devotees travel hundreds of kilometres to Haridwar, collect Ganga water and carry it back to perform 'Jalabishek' (ritual bathing) of Lord Shiva at local shrines.

During the period, Haridwar 'puts on' a saffron hue as teeming multi-

tudes draped in ritual saffron scarfs move through its alleys, with chants of "Bam Bhole" reverberating across the holy city.

Officials expect over four crore 'Kanwariyas' (Kanwar pilgrims) to arrive in Haridwar, with the administration making elaborate arrangements for their convenience and security.

Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami and senior officials have held meetings to review security arrangements, and coordination has also been established with officials in neighbouring states to ensure smooth conduct of the pilgrimage.

Ladakh: 23 heritage sites including petroglyphs, caves and forts declared protected monuments

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

In a landmark initiative aimed at safeguarding Ladakh's rich archaeological, historical and cultural heritage, Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena has approved a notification for declaring 23 heritage sites across the Union Territory as "Protected Monuments" under the provisions of the Jammu and Kashmir Ancient Monuments Preservation Act.

The notification has been issued in view of the immense historical, archaeological and cultural significance of these sites, and marks a major milestone in the preservation of Ladakh's

unique civilisational heritage.

These 23 protected monuments include petroglyph sites, ancient rock carvings, ancient caves, Gompas, caves, forts and palaces among others, that were hitherto lying in dilapidated shape and were under severe threat.

The declaration aims at strengthening heritage conservation efforts in Ladakh by providing legal protection to these historically important sites, facilitating their systematic preservation and restoration, and ensuring that future generations inherit these irreplaceable monuments in their original character and splendour.

"Ladakh's ancient monas-



teries, forts, caves, petroglyphs and rock carvings are invaluable testimonies to our rich civilisational heritage and cultural identity. Their preservation is not merely about protecting monuments but about safeguarding the collective memory of our people for future generations. By declar-

ing these sites as Protected Monuments, we are laying a strong institutional foundation for their scientific conservation, documentation and sustainable management. This initiative reflects our commitment to preserving Ladakh's priceless heritage while promoting



responsible cultural tourism, research and greater public awareness of our unique historical legacy," said LG, Vinai Saxena.

With this notification, the identified monuments shall now enjoy statutory protection under the provisions of the Act, enabling the

Administration to undertake measures for their conservation, prevent encroachments, regulate activities that may endanger their structural integrity, and preserve their historical authenticity.

The 23 sites notified as Protected Monuments include the Petroglyph Site at Shamos;

Maitreya Buddha Rock Carving at Shey near Sindhu Ghat; Tingmosgang Fort; Ancient Caves at Saspol; Petroglyph Sites at Domkhar, Lehdo, Alchi and Murgi; Stongday Gonpa; Meditation Cave of Onpo at Hunder; Hunder Cave; Dechen Tsomo Khar (Fort); Stampuk Cave; Chamba Rock Carving; Zong Chamba (Rock Carving of Maitreya Buddha); Rock-Carved Buddha Statue at Hunder; Rigsum Gonbo Rock Carvings at Diggar; Chamba Karpo (White Maitreya Buddha) at Diggar; Chamba Rock Carving at Tokpo, Diggar; Folang Singey (Boulder-like Lion Face) at Diggar; Sumoor Fort; Rock Inscriptions at Yourbaltak, Kargil; and the Petroglyph Site at Mangmore, Kargil.

Chhattisgarh's Bastar region moving towards new path of development: President Murmu



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday said that Bastar region in Chhattisgarh is moving towards a new path of development and people are coming out of the environment of violence and embracing new opportunities for education, employment and development.

This transformation is a sign of a bright future for Bastar, she said during a meeting with the delegation of "Bastar Mandal", that had called on the president here.

She was happy to note that with the government's efforts and the active participation of the people of Bastar, the region is moving towards a new path of development.

"Amenities such as roads, electricity, and drinking water are reaching even the remotest villages. Schools that had remained closed for long time are once again bustling with children, and the light of education is reaching every household."

"Today, an atmosphere of hope, trust, and progress is taking shape in Bastar. This transformation is a source of joy and pride for the entire nation," Murmu said.

Meeting the delegation, comprising winners of cultural festival Bastar Pandum 2026, the president said that tribal youth are showcasing their talents in various fields such as education, science, art, and sports.

Tribal people have an innate talent in sports and art, Murmu said, and expressed confidence that tribal people will participate in the developmental journey and contribute to nation building while preserving and promoting their cultural identity.

She also underlined the need to work for empowerment of women, children, deprived sections of society and senior citizens.



Editor's
TAKE

NEET Bill: Tougher law, bigger stakes

The LS has passed a Bill to curb exam paper leaks. The real test will be whether the new law plugs the loopholes that allow leaks to occur in the first place

The Lok Sabha's passage of the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026, marks a necessary tightening of India's response to the menace of examination paper leaks. Introduced by Union Minister Jitendra Singh on July 27 and passed by voice vote on July 29 amid Opposition protests, the legislation raises the stakes considerably for those who compromise the integrity of public examinations.

Under the amendments, individuals involved in unfair means can face five to ten years in prison and a fine of up to ₹50 lakh. For organised examination fraud, the minimum imprisonment rises to seven years and the minimum fine to ₹10 crore. Service providers can face higher penalties and an eight-year debarment. The Bill also provides for special fast-track courts, the completion of investigations within two months, and trials within three months of the filing of a chargesheet.

There is little doubt that such provisions are welcome. Paper leaks are not minor administrative lapses. They destroy the credibility of examinations, waste years of students' lives and reward dishonesty at the expense of merit. A strong deterrent is therefore essential. Speedy prosecution is equally important because a law that takes years to secure convictions can hardly deter an organised racket.

Yet, the Opposition has a point that deserves serious consideration: a tougher law does not automatically create a leak-proof examination system. Congress Deputy Leader Gaurav Gogoi pointed out that leaks continued despite the 2024 law and questioned the effectiveness of the existing institutional framework. Other Opposition members argued that the Bill concentrates on punishment while failing to address wider systemic weaknesses and accountability.

The Opposition's objections, therefore, should not be reduced to opposition for opposition's sake. Nor should the government dismiss every criticism as political obstruction. The real question is whether prevention has received as much attention as punishment. The government itself has acknowledged the need for broader reform by setting up a high-powered panel on examination reforms. An earlier expert committee made 101 recommendations, including greater use of computer-based testing and multiple shifts, but several important measures have yet to be fully implemented.

The way forward must therefore be comprehensive. Every stage of the examination chain—from paper setting and printing to encryption, transportation, storage, distribution and digital access—must be independently audited. Service providers need stringent background checks, financial scrutiny and real-time security monitoring. Technology must be used not merely after a leak but to make leaks substantially harder in the first place. The NTA and other examination bodies must also have clearly defined accountability, with responsibility fixed at the appropriate level when serious failures occur. The new law can be a strong deterrent, but it cannot, by itself, restore public faith. India needs a tougher, smarter and more accountable examination system.

The seas need rules, not just warships

The Gulf crisis highlights the need for a stronger rules-based maritime order, with the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS) at its core. For a maritime power like the United States, which follows many UNCLOS principles but has never ratified the convention, the debate carries significance far beyond its own shores



SANTHOSH
MATHEW

US Coast Guard Day, observed on August 4, comes at a time when the world's attention is again focused on the Persian Gulf and the Strait of Hormuz. Rising tensions in the region have once again shown how closely maritime security is connected with energy, trade and global peace.

The US Coast Guard has a long history of protecting American waters, rescuing people at sea, preventing smuggling and helping ships in distress. Its role also reflects a larger reality of the modern world: the oceans are too important to be governed solely by naval power. They need common rules accepted by countries.

The most important international framework for this purpose is the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea, or UNCLOS. It is widely regarded as the basic legal framework for the world's oceans. It covers navigation, territorial waters, maritime boundaries, fishing, seabed resources, marine pollution and the rights of coastal countries.

The United States signed UNCLOS in 1982 but has not ratified it. The US Senate has never approved the Convention. American objections have included the original provisions dealing with deep-seabed mining, international dispute settlement, military activities at sea and concerns about national sovereignty. The deep-seabed provisions were later revised through the 1994 Agreement.

America's position remains unusual. Although it is not a party to UNCLOS, the United States accepts many of its basic navigation rules as customary international law. Washington strongly supports freedom of navigation and regularly challenges maritime claims it considers excessive.

The continuing tension in the Persian Gulf makes this issue especially important. The Gulf is a narrow and crowded maritime region surrounded by several countries. It contains some of the world's most important oil and gas resources. The Strait of Hormuz connects the Gulf with the Arabian Sea and the wider Indian Ocean. It is one of the world's most important energy routes.

Any disruption in the Strait can affect oil supplies, shipping costs, energy prices and economies far beyond West Asia. The impact can reach India, China, Japan, Europe and many other parts of the world.

UNCLOS provides a basic system for managing maritime spaces. A coastal country can claim a territorial sea of up to 12 nautical miles from its baselines. It exercises sovereignty in this area, subject to international law and the right of



innocent passage for foreign ships.

Beyond the territorial sea lies the Exclusive Economic Zone (EEZ), which can extend up to 200 nautical miles. The EEZ is not an extension of national territory. A coastal country has special rights over natural resources such as fish, oil and gas, while other countries retain important freedoms of navigation and overflight.

This distinction is particularly important in crowded maritime regions. A country cannot treat its entire 200-nautical-mile EEZ as territorial waters. International law balances the economic rights of coastal states with the navigation rights of other countries.

UNCLOS also provides rules for international straits, continental shelves, fisheries, marine environmental protection, scientific research and the peaceful settlement of maritime disputes. It has helped bring a degree of order to an ocean covering most of the planet.

India is a party to UNCLOS and has a strong interest in maintaining this rules-based maritime order. India's long coastline, island territories and vast EEZ make the law of the sea central to its national interests.

India's economic future is closely connected with the ocean. A large part of India's international trade moves by sea. Energy supplies from the Persian Gulf are particularly important. Millions of Indians live and work in Gulf countries, making stability in the region important not only for India's economy but also for millions of families.

The Strait of Hormuz, therefore, has a direct connection with India. Any prolonged disturbance in the Strait can increase energy costs, affect shipping and put pressure on the Indian economy.

The issue also has a wider strategic dimen-

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Three habits that happy people practise every day



NISHANT
GARG

2ND OPINION

After 13 years of working with individuals in business, academia and government, I have identified three important habits of people who tend to be happier each day.

These habits — deliberate practice, appreciation and equanimity — are not philosophical constructs but practical tools for becoming a little happier each day.

Being deliberate makes a big difference. It's easy to assume that I will be happy only when I get what I want, but it takes deliberate decision-making to be happy most of the time and sad only when things go extremely wrong.

This is what I call your proactive tendency. Are you taking small steps every day to become more open to change (if things don't happen your way), or are you



becoming more rigid?

This brings us to the next habit: appreciating what you have. Appreciation is not about waiting for something great before you value it; rather, it is your ability to savour the process as well. Research in neuroscience suggests that the brain systems driving 'wanting' are separate from those producing 'liking'. That is why

people who do not appreciate the process tend to chase after things they think will make them happy, but once they have them, it feels like nothing. It gives happiness only momentarily.

The last and most important pillar that will help you practise both of the above is equanimity. Things will not always go your way; there are no linear pathways in life. Your plans will fail, people will change, and you might lose things you value. That is what Buddha meant when he said that life is suffering because we don't understand that things are anicca (impermanent).

Recognise that you can only change a few things every day (through deliberate practice), appreciate the process, and remain equanimous when the path is hard. A military veteran I once taught said,

"Under extreme pressure, the calmest soldiers were not those who were the bravest but those who were the most accepting that things would not go their way." Hold your ground and change only what you can. Take the middle path.

The writer is Faculty IIM Indore

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SUPREME COURT VERDICT PUTS GOVERNMENT-CJP DEAL IN DOUBT

The uncertainty surrounding the agreement reached between the Government and the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) following the Supreme Court's refusal to grant blanket immunity to those named in the FIRs is both significant and perplexing.

The Supreme Court has once again drawn a clear constitutional line between the democratic right to protest and the rule of law, a distinction essential in a free democracy like India. Constitutional rights cannot come at the cost of legal accountability.

Against this backdrop, the CJP's threat to resume its agitation unless all criminal cases are withdrawn raises serious concerns.

During the hearing, the Court observed that the allegations appeared serious enough to

warrant a fair and independent investigation. While protest is a democratic right, compelling the judiciary or the executive to abandon due legal process is not. Political pressure cannot replace judicial determination.

At the same time, the Supreme Court adopted a balanced approach by directing the immediate release of arrested protesters with no criminal record and granting interim protection against coercive action in the FIRs. It also recognised that minors and innocent participants should not face unnecessary criminal proceedings.

The Court's approach upholds both constitutional freedoms and the rule of law, reinforcing public confidence in the justice system.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com.
In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

School junk food ban must be enforced strictly

The Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) has decided to ban packaged foods and drinks high in fat, sugar and salt (HFSS) within 50 metres of school premises. It has also prohibited the sale, advertisement and free distribution of HFSS food items. In addition, kitchen operators and food suppliers must possess valid licences.

Covering children from 22 months of age up to Class XII in all schools, this move could prove to be a game-changer if implemented effectively. Popular snacks such as vada pav and samosas will now be off-limits to children, at least during school hours. Bakery products, chocolates and sugary aerated drinks remain among the most popular junk foods consumed by children.

As these foods are highly appealing, youngsters often consume them without understanding their nutritional value or long-term health consequences. Schools should also monitor the food children bring from home. Kobo toolkits, as used in Bihar, can help assess students' food consumption and monitor kitchen hygiene. Linking all districts through this system would enable regular assessments and monthly reports, ensuring healthier school environments and better nutrition for children.

GANAPATHI BHAT | AKOLA

Paper leaks demand lasting reforms

The cancellation and rescheduling of NEET UG 2026 following widespread question paper leaks, along with the reported suicides of at least 21 students, exposed the urgent need for stronger examination reforms. NEET UG and its predecessor, AIPMT, have faced repeated paper leak controversies in 2015, 2016, 2021, 2024 and 2026. Reports of numerous such incidents over the past decade highlight a disturbing pattern that cannot be ignored.

Investigations into major examination leaks over the past two decades have rarely resulted in long-term imprisonment for those responsible. While modern communication technologies have made paper leaks easier to execute, they have also provided investigators with better tools to uncover organised rackets. The focus must therefore shift from reactive measures to stronger prevention and accountability.

The indefinite dharna organised by the Cockroach Janata Party at Jantar Mantar and the subsequent "Chalo Sansad" march reflected growing frustration among young people over examination irregularities. The Government later accepted the CJP's five-point demands. Though delayed, these steps offer hope for a more transparent, secure and fair examination system.

HARIDASAN RAJAN | KERALA

Respect experts, avoid personal attacks

Congress MP Priyanka Vadra's criticism of the inclusion of IIT Madras Director V Kamakoti on the Centre's examination reform task force was in poor taste. Referring to him as a "Gaumutra (cow urine) expert" in Parliament diminished the quality of public debate.

Kamakoti is a renowned scientist, Padma Shri awardee and an expert in cyber security, artificial intelligence and computer architecture. At a Mattu Pongal event in Chennai, he stated that cow urine possesses anti-bacterial, anti-fungal and digestive properties, and shared an anecdote about its purported therapeutic benefits.

Modern medicine has not conclusively established or disproved many claims made by practitioners of alternative medicine. When a distinguished scientist expresses such views, they should be debated on scientific evidence rather than ridiculed through personal attacks. Differences of opinion are natural, but criticism should remain respectful.

Members of Parliament enjoy constitutional immunity for statements made inside the House. However, that privilege should not be used to make derogatory remarks about individuals with distinguished professional reputations. Parliamentary discourse should uphold dignity, civility and respect, even in disagreement.

V JAYARAMAN | CHENNAI

Mangroves: The foundation of coastal resilience

Mangroves are living shields that protect shorelines, absorb carbon, sustain fisheries and livelihoods, and offer a vital line of defence against an increasingly unpredictable climate. For India, protecting these green barriers is not merely an environmental responsibility — it is an investment in national resilience and human survival



SATENDRA SINGH

In a period of rapid climate change, rising sea level, increasing storms and coastal disasters, mangroves have become not just forests but natural life support systems that protect humans and the environment as well. In case of a large country like India, which has more than 7,500 kilometers of coastline and millions of people who live in coastal regions of India, the conservation of mangroves is no more an issue of the environment; it is an important step towards creating resilience of the nation against disasters and climate change, providing ecological security and sustainable development. While nations spend billions on building protective structures such as sea walls, embankments etc., nature has created an efficient, self-renewing and inexpensive defence system in the shape of mangrove forests.

The mangroves are one of the best examples of Nature-based Solutions (NbS) and Ecosystem-based Disaster Risk Reduction (Eco-DRR). They show how ecosystems conservation can help in safeguarding the biodiversity, improve livelihoods, reduce disaster risks, and even mitigate climate change at the same time. Each hectare of healthy mangrove forest represents an example of living green infrastructure that provides much more than any engineering structure.

Mangroves include a special type of plants represented by salt-resistant trees and shrubs growing in the transition area between the land and the sea. Being located in the tidal zones, river deltas, lagoons, and bays, mangroves are special organisms that have developed amazing adaptation mechanisms that allow them to live in such specific conditions. Their intricate prop roots are very helpful in providing stability against powerful currents and surges. Pneumatophores are breathing roots growing upwards, allowing them to breathe in the oxygen in the oxygen-deficient sediment. This adaptation leads to the formation of extensive and dense root systems, which bind sediments and help stabilize the shorelines, besides providing shelter to a multitude of aquatic creatures. Ecologically, mangroves serve as an important interface between the terrestrial, freshwater, and marine ecosystems.

Rich Mangrove heritage of India

India is blessed with some of the most abundant mangrove vegetation in the world, which spans an area of around 5,000 square kilometres along the east and west coasts and islands of the country. Mangroves have been found growing in varied climatic and geomorphological zones, each unique in its biodiversity.

Notable among Indian mangroves is the Sundarbans, which is the largest continuous mangrove forest in the world, shared by India and Bangladesh, and home to the majestic Royal Bengal Tigers. Another equally important site of mangroves is that of Bhitarkanika in Odisha, the river delta areas of Godavari, Krishna and Mahanadi, Pichavaram mangroves of Tamil Nadu, Gulf of Kachchh in Gujarat, and Andaman and Nicobar Islands. The mangrove forests house many plants, fish, crustaceans, mollusks, reptiles, amphibians and migratory birds.

In terms of climate action, mangroves are very special ecosystems as they are blue carbon ecosystems. They absorb carbon dioxide in the atmosphere through the process of photosynthesis and accumulate very high amounts of carbon in their biomass and soil. Scientific evidence suggests that mangroves are capable of storing several times more carbon per hectare than many tropical forests. Therefore, protecting mangroves is one of the best ways of mitigating the effects of climate change.

Their socio-economic importance is also immense. Millions of coastal people make their living through fishing, gathering of crabs, honey collection, eco-tourism, sustainable harvesting of forest products and the services provided by mangroves. However, perhaps their greatest contribution is the ability to safeguard human lives and property from the destructive effects of cyclones, storm surges, and even tsunamis — a potential that only becomes visible in times of crisis. With increasing frequency of natural disasters along coastal areas due to global climate change, these natural green walls have become an integral part of the solution. As a consequence of rising sea levels and warming of oceans, people residing in low-lying coastal



areas are becoming vulnerable to many risks. Under such conditions of increased risk, mangrove forests have become one of the best defences that mother nature provides. Concrete seawalls offer resistance against waves. On the other hand, mangroves not only offer resistance but also dissipate wave energy due to their trunk, branches and root system. Mangroves lower the wave height and velocity and protect the shorelines by stabilising them and by reducing coastal erosion. The role of mangroves during the occurrence of cyclones and storm surges is that of a natural bio-shield that reduces flood impact and protects life, agriculture, infrastructure and livelihoods. Studies after some cyclones and 2004 Indian Ocean Tsunami indicate that the areas with degraded mangrove belt were heavily impacted while those protected by mangroves suffered little and recovered faster.

In case of India, with 7,500-km long coastline and coastal districts being densely populated, mangroves play an important role in terms of environmental conservation as well as strategic investment. There has been increasing appreciation of Eco-Disaster Risk Reduction (Eco-DRR), making the conservation of natural ecosystems a crucial part of disaster management. In contrast to traditional grey infrastructure like seawalls and embankments, mangroves are living green infrastructure that becomes stronger over time, does not need much maintenance, and provides several co-benefits including conservation of biodiversity, carbon sequestration, improved fish stocks, and sustainable livelihoods. The combination of mangroves and artificial measures of protection results in a more sustainable and cost-efficient system of disaster management of coastal areas. This approach is entirely consistent with Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction, Paris Agreement, and the Sustainable Development Goals that view healthy ecosystems as a key part of climate change resilience and sustainable development.

Lessons from major disasters

Perhaps none of the events has highlighted the role of mangroves better than the tsunami that hit the Indian Ocean in 2004. More than 230,000 people lost their lives in fourteen different countries due to the deadly tsunami. However, post-disaster analysis showed a clear trend where coastal villages having dense mangroves forests witnessed much less devastation than those areas where mangroves had been cleared out for any kind of developmental work such as aquaculture and urbanisation.

Some of the coastal stretches in Tamil Nadu with intact mangrove forest witnessed lower wave energy impact and consequently low devastation from the deadly waves. The same was seen in some regions in Andaman and Nicobar Islands, Sri Lanka, and Indonesia.

Another lesson from major disasters where mangrove has played an important role is the super cyclone in 1999. During the 1999 super cyclone in Odisha, the mangrove forests in

Bhitarkanika acted as natural bio-shield against the cyclone by lowering the speed of wind and storm surge before they hit inland areas.

Such experience shows an essential lesson that restoration of one hectare of mangroves before disasters is always cheaper than restoration of infrastructure destroyed in the process.

Development of effective disaster management policies in coastal areas is impossible without the integration of engineering solutions with ecosystem protection. It is necessary to build shelters, embankments, early warning systems, resilient houses and plan evacuations, but all this will be much more efficient if there are healthy mangrove belts as a first line of defence.

In light of the growing threats brought about by climate change, governments need to start looking at mangroves as an important part of natural infrastructure that needs to be planned, developed and protected just like roads, ports and energy networks. The cost involved in protecting mangroves is negligible when compared to the huge losses human beings could suffer due to coastal disasters in the future.

While mangroves hold great ecological and economic significance, they continue to be subjected to greater pressure because of urbanisation, industrial growth, aquaculture, development of coastal infrastructure, pollution, reckless tourism and climate change impacts such as sea level rise and salinisation. The conservation and protection of this fragile ecosystem need to go beyond just plantation to scientific management and conservation on a landscape scale.

Initiatives like the Mangrove Initiative for Shoreline Habitats and Tangible Incomes (MISHTI), Integrated Coastal Zone Management, Green India Mission and state-wise restoration projects have been initiated in India. Yet, their success in the future will be dependent upon the incorporation of mangrove conservation in coastal development plans, disaster management planning and climate change policy making. Advanced technologies like remote sensing, GIS, drones, Artificial Intelligence and satellite-based monitoring could transform the process of mangrove mapping, health assessment and restoration. An equally important aspect would be community engagement that holds the key to conservation of these ecosystems. Sustained livelihood through fishing, eco-tourism, honey and blue carbon funding could provide strong economic motivation for conservation. The protection of the mangroves is imperative and should be seen as vital natural infrastructure. Every coastal region should include the protection and restoration of the mangroves in their Disaster Management Plan, Climate Action Plan, and Coastal Zone Management Plan. Investment in the restoration of the mangroves should be seen as investments in reducing disaster risks, climate resilience and economic security.

The writer is the former Executive Director, National Institute of Disaster Management, Government of India

The enduring bond between alumni and their alma mater



ANURADHA P S

The unexpected energy of the courtyard was the same as 25 years before: laughter weaved its way through the trees, a gentle buzz of voices sharing stories, and the faces crowding under the college arch. The theme of the evening was not only “Rewind” but the actual feel of returning alumni to celebrate, reconnect, and reflect. From its inception, a band of students has since evolved into a sturdy alumni family, where each member has an individual story to tell about the college.

As students arrived back then, the campus was a place to discover. Clubs, study groups and late-night talks were introduced during freshers’ week and linked strangers together as companions. The early connections grew stronger with group assignments, campus festivals, and the intense competition of exams. The students were varied and energetic: artists, coders, activists, athletes and thinkers who exchanged thoughts in the library, on the field and over a cup of chai. This diversity has been a hallmark of the alumni community, and continues to be a rich source of talents and perspectives that enhance every alumni gathering and effort.

The alumnus was transformed into a network of individuals over the years and now consists of a group of people. The alumnus has grown from a list of names, into a living network over the years, and is now a collection of individuals. It’s the managers creating sustainable solutions, teachers influencing young minds, entrepreneurs starting businesses and professionals securing meaningful careers across a range of industries. A lot of people have turned their passions at the campus into meaningful careers. A surprising majority says that work today is “satisfying”, not just “stable”, when queried. Work offered growth, values and creative contribution.

Replays of the best songs of youth drifted about throughout the night. There were tales of late-night trips to the library when deadlines were near, and someone was always there with a cup of coffee; there were stories of the impromptu drama performances that used empty classrooms as stages; there were stories of the cricket team’s untimely triumph that brought the campus to a state of celebration. Nostalgia was lodged in the mundane: A cherished bench beside the canteen, graffiti on the arts block, and an old notice-board covered in posters from past fests. Such common memories are not just funny; they are a bond that connects alumni over time, and they foster a sense of the moments that formed them.



One of the most heartbreaking events was when I, who had been a teacher since those days and am still one today, encountered the class that graduated in 2001. It was an amazing experience to see those faces, which were once mine, those of my students, now seasoned professionals themselves, and parents. They spoke with ease; they spoke of the careers they had built and made their own with the foundation we provided them in our classrooms, of the challenges they faced and how they grew in that experience, of how the values we talked about then continue to guide them. I heard from them about their families, their work and their small joys. The exchange was a good reminder that teaching is an ongoing conversation; the teacher-student relationship evolves but never ends.

In addition to the nostalgia, it highlighted that the evening was a testament to the fact that alumni are the lifeline of long-term relationships with an institution. The alumni association is not just a roll call, it is a community that has a forward momentum and is reciprocal, contributing to the college’s ongoing vitality and future. Alumni provide institutional memory, mentoring, and materials and are a link to industry and research and to civic life. Their connection provides job opportunities, internships, and project connections for current students, and also serves as a way for alumni to remain connected to a place that helped make them. This is “affection made concrete” – memories of friends and family inspire tangible commitments that invest in the institution.

This was the point made evident by a number of concrete projects announced that night. Alumni will be matched with students for career advice in mentorship programs, internships will be arranged at alumni workplaces and collaborative projects will bring together student teams to work with advisors from industry. Finally, several alumni made commitments to hosting workshops, supporting research, and supporting campus festivals. These pledges demonstrate the power of an organized alumni community.

As the night drew close, groups stayed under the light and reminisced about their favorite moments, some taking pictures that would be shared on social media timelines. It was more than just a smile of memory; it was a smile of reassurance: friendships last through the years, careers can be rewarding and the ties that bind alumni together are unbroken. Rewind was more than an evening, it was a testament to the fact that the college’s history lives on in its people.

Many people felt lighter walking away, as they had reconnected and had plans for the future. The alumni went back to their lives with new networks and new purpose; empowered by the great feeling that comes when they are part of an alumni community that will remember, support and celebrate them.

The writer is a Professor in the Department of Commerce, CHRIST (Deemed to be University)

Why trims may be sustainable fashion’s most overlooked contributors



SHARMILA DAS

Sustainability has become fashion’s favourite conversation. Brands proudly discuss organic cotton, recycled polyester, regenerative agriculture, renewable energy, water conservation, carbon footprints and circularity. Industry conferences are filled with ambitious targets and inspiring presentations. Reports are published. Commitments are announced. Awards are presented. And meanwhile, somewhere in a garment factory, a small zipper is wondering why nobody has invited it to the discussion.

The reality is that sustainability in fashion often resembles a group photograph where everyone crowds around the fabric while the trims are accidentally cropped out of the frame.

Yet these seemingly insignificant components—buttons, zippers, sewing threads, labels, elastics, drawcords, rivets, eyelets and other trims—may have a far greater influence on a garment’s real-world sustainability than many people realise. The fashion industry has become remarkably skilled at talking about what a garment is made of. It is still learning to talk about everything attached to it. Consider a simple example. A jacket made from recycled polyester sounds like a sustainability success story. But what happens if the zipper is made from a different material, the sewing thread from another, the labels from yet another, and the

decorative trims from several more? Suddenly, the garment that appeared recyclable becomes significantly more challenging to recycle at the end of its life. The fabric receives the sustainability headline. The trims quietly complicate the outcome—unless the brand consciously uses recycled-material trims, in which at least 30-50 per cent less virgin material is used.

Or consider durability. A garment may be made from an exceptionally sustainable fabric. Yet if a button falls off after a few uses or a zipper fails within months, the consumer’s relationship with that product changes immediately. The garment may be discarded, replaced or forgotten in a wardrobe. In sustainability terms, the environmental impact of a failed trim is rarely limited to the trim itself. Sometimes a ten-gram component determines the future of a five-hundred-gram garment. That is a remarkable amount of influence for something most consumers never notice.

If trims could speak, they might reasonably ask for better representation. After all, sustainability is not simply about what enters a product. It is equally about how long that product remains useful, repairable, reusable and recyclable.

And trims influence every one of those outcomes. A thoughtfully selected zipper can extend product life. A durable button can reduce replacement frequency. A repair-friendly fastening can encourage continued use. A responsibly sourced label can improve transparency. A recyclable trim can support circularity. A traceable trim can strengthen supply chain accountability.

None of these decisions generates the excitement of a revolutionary new fibre. Yet collectively, they shape the practical reality of sustainable fashion. Perhaps this is why trims remind me of yoga. When people first encounter yoga, they often focus on the visible aspects—the postures, the flexibility and the impressive poses. These receive attention because they are easy to see. What receives less attention are the quieter elements: the breath, the alignment, the awareness and the consistency of practice. Yet experienced practitioners know that these invisible factors often determine the effectiveness of the entire experience. The pose may attract attention. The breath creates transformation. Fashion sustainability faces a similar challenge. The fabric attracts attention. The details often determine performance.



Much like yoga students who eagerly attempt advanced postures while forgetting to breathe, the industry occasionally becomes fascinated by large sustainability ambitions while overlooking the smaller decisions that support them. The result can be surprisingly familiar.

An impressive sustainability claim attached to a product that is difficult to repair. A recyclable garment that cannot be efficiently recycled. A durable fabric paired with components that fail prematurely. A circularity strategy interrupted by non-circular design choices.

In other words, sustainability is holding its breath.

Yoga teaches that balance emerges when all parts of a system work together. Fashion sustainability is beginning to learn the same lesson. A garment is not a fabric with accessories. It is a system. And systems succeed or fail through the interaction of all their parts.

This perspective becomes increasingly important as brands pursue circularity. The future of sustainable fashion depends on products that generate less waste and can be easily repaired, disassembled, recycled, reused and recovered. Achieving this will require not only innovative fabrics but also thoughtfully designed trims. Can components be easily separated? Can materials be accurately identified? Can damaged parts be replaced? Can products remain functional for longer? Can end-of-life processing be made simpler? These questions often lead directly back to trims. The industry is taking cognisance of all these issues and monitoring them, but much more needs to be done. The concept is still nascent but is evolving. Ironically, the smaller the component, the easier it is to overlook. Yet sustainability repeatedly teaches the same lesson: small decisions create large consequences.

A few grams of unnecessary packaging, multi-

plied by millions of units, become significant waste. A more thoughtful trim specification can influence durability, recyclability and resource efficiency throughout an entire product lifecycle. The impact may be hidden. The results are not.

Perhaps the greatest opportunity lies in changing how we think about sustainability itself. For many years, sustainability has been associated with grand gestures—major innovations, transformative technologies, ambitious targets and industry-wide commitments. These remain important. But lasting progress often emerges from quieter improvements repeated consistently across systems.

Once again, yoga offers a useful reminder: lasting benefits come not from a single spectacular session but from small actions practised consistently over time. Sustainable fashion progresses in much the same way — one material choice, one design improvement, one repair-friendly feature and one responsibly sourced trim at a time. The future of fashion will require not only innovation but also attention to the details that determine whether sustainability works in practice rather than merely in theory. So, the next time sustainability conversations focus only on fabrics, spare a thought for the quiet contributors standing just outside the spotlight — the button, the zipper, the label, the thread and the elastic. While the fabric may become famous, the button may very well save the planet.

The writer is a trained Sivananda Yoga teacher



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Order Order

SPP to conduct trial against Senthil Balaji, TN to SC



Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay-led Government in Tamil Nadu on Thursday informed the Supreme Court that it has appointed a Special Public Prosecutor (SPP) to conduct trials against former DMK minister V Senthil Balaji in the cash-for-job scam-related cases where over 2,000 persons have been implicated as accused.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana was told by Additional Advocate General Hairpriya Padmanabhan for Tamil Nadu that the Government has appointed a SPP to conduct the trial against the former minister, and if the need arises, it is willing to appoint an Additional Public Prosecutor (APP) for expeditious disposal of the case.

Advocate Pranav Sachdeva, appearing for one Y Balaji, said that the main issue was not the appointment of SPP or APP but it was the clubbing of cases related to the scam, as they have named more than 2,000 accused in the matter to delay the proceedings. The bench said it would hear the matter in detail on August 11 and adjourned it. The top court was hearing a petition filed by Y Balaji, challenging the Madras High Court order of March 28, 2025, which dismissed pleas against the clubbing of multiple chargesheets in cases related to the alleged scam. (PTI)

Bombay HC grants interim relief to Sameer Wankhede



In an interim relief, the Bombay High Court on Thursday shielded NCB's former zonal director Sameer Wankhede from questioning in the enquiries initiated against him for alleged irregularities in two cases pending final hearing of his petition.

Wankhede, a 2008-batch Indian Revenue Service (IRS) officer, had filed a petition in the HC in 2024 challenging the notices issued to him then on the Narcotics Control Bureau's (NCB) enquiries over irregularities in two drug cases, including one related to actor Sushant Singh Rajput's death. While the NCB claimed the enquiries were initiated on the basis of two anonymous complaints, Wankhede alleged that the same were at the behest of former Maharashtra minister Nawab Malik, who he claimed nursed a grudge against him as he had arrested Malik's son-in-law Sameer Khan in a drugs case.

A division bench of Justices Ajay Gadkari and Kamal Khata on Thursday admitted Wankhede's petition and said until the plea is finally heard and decided, the petitioner shall not be summoned for questioning.

The NCB had earlier submitted to the HC that there were serious and grave allegations of irregularities against Wankhede and hence enquiries were initiated against him.

After Rajput allegedly committed suicide at his residence in Mumbai in June 2020, the NCB initiated a probe into alleged drug use in the film industry.

The agency later registered a case of alleged possession, consumption and financing of drugs against Rajput's girlfriend Rhea Chakraborty, her brother Showik and 33 others. (PTI)

Driver's invalid licence bars accident compensation: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday said that insurance companies are not liable to pay compensation for accidents if the driver's licence was not valid or not renewed at the time of the incident.

The top court said that an insurance company could not be saddled with the liability if the offending vehicle was driven without a valid driving licence. Referring to the issue of vehicles being driven without valid licences, the top court said that it leads to a situation where a driver or an owner or both will have to pay huge amounts as compensation in accident cases, and called for a nationwide campaign to make citizens aware.

A bench comprising



Justices Sanjay Karol and N Kotiswar Singh asked the Union Ministry of Road, Transport and Highways and state transport departments to run a nationwide campaign to promote road safety and strengthen compliance with traffic laws. It asked them to undertake extensive awareness drives through social media and other platforms while streamlining the issuance and renewal of driving licences.

The court also stressed the need for urgent reforms in



The NEET 2026 agitation – Youth, democracy and the future of India



ARUN BHARDWAJ

In 1947, when India attained Independence, its population was approximately 350 million. Today, India's population has grown to nearly 1.5 billion. Out of this, nearly 350-400 million citizens belong to the younger generation, commonly referred to as Generation Z (Gen-Z). This demographic constitutes one of the country's greatest strengths and has the potential to shape India's future in significant ways.

Every morning in India's metropolitan cities, one can witness thousands of young men and women riding motorcycles, scooters, bicycles and public transport with backpacks on their shoulders, rushing to their workplaces or educational institutions. They often compete for every available space on the roads, reflecting not only the pressures of urban life but also their determination to build successful careers. This generation understands the value of education, employment and financial independence. At the same time, lakhs of students aspire to become doctors, engineers, professionals and Government officers. Similar scenes can be witnessed in rural India, where young farmers work diligently in their fields despite adverse weather conditions. Members of the labour class also continue to work tirelessly in scorching summers and freezing winters. There are numerous inspiring examples of children from economically weaker sections who have studied under streetlights and eventually risen to become senior Government officers and accomplished professionals. These stories symbolise the resilience and aspirations of India's youth.

The leakage of examination papers is unfortunately not a new phenomenon in India. The National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET) was introduced by the Government of India in 2013 as a common entrance examination for admission to undergrad-

uate medical, dental and allied healthcare courses. Since its inception, NEET has periodically faced allegations of question paper leaks. Similar allegations have also surfaced from time to time in respect of several competitive examinations conducted by both the Central and State Governments. However, based on information available in the public domain, such incidents had generally remained localised and had never escalated into a nationwide public movement.

The situation changed dramatically in 2026. Allegations regarding the leakage of the NEET examination paper generated widespread concern among students and parents across the country. Reports suggested that the uncertainty created by the controversy, coupled with examination pressure and the cancellation of the original examination, allegedly contributed to nearly twenty student suicides nationwide. To restore confidence in the examination process, the Government conducted a nationwide re-examination on June 21, 2026. More than 1.7 million students appeared for the examination, and over 900,000 candidates successfully qualified.

During this period, a person reportedly residing abroad announced the formation of a forum called the "Cockroach Janta Party" (CJP). Within a remarkably short span of time, the organisation attracted widespread attention. It was reported that lakhs of people began following its social media platforms and applied for membership. Thus, the emergence of CJP became one of the most talked-about developments arising out of the controversy.

The rapid growth of CJP surprised many observers. Its founder, Abhijeet Dipke, appointed spokespersons and other office-bearers to establish the organisation. Questions were raised by various sections of society regarding its sources of funding. Some individuals strongly believe that the organisation may be receiving support from anti-India groups or other entities having political interests in India or seeking to influence the country's political narrative. These concerns continue to remain matters of public debate. It is expected that CJP will maintain complete transparency regarding its funding and organisational functioning.



Realising that its supporters expected concrete action, CJP announced peaceful and non-violent protests. It demanded the resignation of the Union Education Minister, comprehensive reforms in the education and examination system, and financial compensation for the families of students who had allegedly committed suicide during the controversy. Social activist and innovator Sonam Wangchuk, known among other things for his significant patent holdings and educational initiatives, extended his support to these demands.

Many observers believed that the Government of India did not initially respond with adequate urgency or engage in meaningful dialogue with the protesters. As media coverage expanded, demonstrations spread across the country. India has always taken pride in its tradition of Ahimsa (non-violence), and the protests were announced as peaceful demonstrations. However, it was also alleged that certain disruptive elements infiltrated the movement and attempted to disturb its peaceful character, resulting in isolated incidents of violence and clashes between protesters and the police.

The removal of Sonam Wangchuk from the protest site at Jantar Mantar reportedly became a turning point, triggering the arrival of thousands of additional protesters at the venue. Faced with increasing public pressure and widespread demonstrations, the Government ultimately

accepted a majority of the demands raised by CJP.

The unprecedented growth of CJP and the developments surrounding the NEET controversy have undoubtedly altered the country's political discourse. India currently has nearly 350 million young citizens belonging to Gen-Z, many of whom are receptive to new ideas and emerging platforms. CJP has already announced its intention to raise several additional public issues in the future. Although the organisation has not formally aligned itself with any major political party, discussions regarding the political affiliations of some of its office-bearers, including their reported association with the Aam Aadmi Party, continue in the public domain.

Generational participation has always played a significant role in shaping India's democratic evolution. In PUCL v. Union of India (2003) 4 SCC 399, the Supreme Court observed that the Fundamental Rights enshrined in the Constitution do not have fixed content. The Court remarked that, over time, it has filled "the skeleton with soul and blood and made it vibrant." It further observed that "most of the Fundamental Rights are empty vessels into which each generation must pour its content in the light of its experience."

Part III of the Constitution of India guarantees Fundamental Rights such as the Right to Equality, Freedom of Speech and Expression,

the Right to Assemble Peacefully, the Right to Form Associations or Unions, and the Right to Life and Personal Liberty. These rights have consistently been recognised as forming part of the Constitution's Basic Structure. Article 13 further provides that Parliament cannot enact laws that are inconsistent with or violate these Fundamental Rights.

Article 19 of the Constitution of India guarantees (a) Freedom of Speech and Expression, (b) to assemble peacefully and without arms, (c) to form association or unions. During protests and thereafter serious allegations of violence between Protesters and Police was reported. In view of the above Fundamental Rights, the Supreme Court Bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant issued salutary balanced interim directions, directing release of all the detained student protestors under 18 years age who do not have any criminal records. It directed preservation of all CCTV Footage, drawn recording, PCR Log relating to demonstration. The order barred coercive steps against student protesters without past criminal antecedents and allowed ongoing enquiries without harsh steps. These directions have been accepted and welcomed by all.

In independent India, only a few nationwide public movements have significantly influenced the country's political landscape. The Jayaprakash Narayan Movement ultimately led to the formation of the Janata Party, while the Anna Hazare anti-corruption movement paved the way for the emergence of the Aam Aadmi Party. Both movements eventually contributed to changes in the political landscape and the formation of Governments at the Centre.

Only time will determine the ultimate impact of the NEET 2026 agitation. CJP has neither formally declared its intention to enter electoral politics nor ruled out such a possibility. However, if the organisation succeeds in sustaining its growth, expanding its public support and eventually entering the political arena, it could emerge as a significant challenge to established political parties that have governed India in the past or continue to hold power today.

The author is a senior advocate

SC permits Muslims to offer Friday prayers on dargah land near Bhojshala complex

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Supreme Court on Thursday permitted Muslims to offer Friday prayers at the premises of a dargah adjacent to the disputed Bhojshala complex at Dhar in Madhya Pradesh. The top court directed the State Government to ensure that Muslims are allowed to offer *namaz* at the site between 1 and 3 pm on Fridays.

A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, however, said that the instant direction does not preclude the State Government and the Muslim side from exploring another site for Friday prayers with mutual consent.

On July 14, the bench had directed that a separate open space be provided adjacent to the disputed site in Dhar for *namaz* on Fridays between 1 and 3 pm till the case is decided.

Later, the Muslim side led by Haji Muneer Ahmad moved the top court alleging non-compliance with its directions to provide an alternative site, saying that the Dhar administration was providing the place which was 1.3 km away from the disputed Bhojshala complex.

They said that the site should be close enough from where Muslims can sight the mosque while offering prayers. After hearing arguments from senior advocate Huzefa Ahmadi, appearing for the Muslim side, and Additional Solicitor General KM Natraj, on behalf of the State

Government, clarified its earlier order of July 14.

"The earlier order is clarified to the extent that the Muslim community be permitted to offer *namaz* on Fridays between 1-3 pm at the land being Khasra No. 596 which is stated to be Dargah land. Copy of the site plan produced shows that it has an independent and separate access road and therefore the said site appears to be suitable. It is adjacent to the subject premises," the CJ said in the order.

"This order shall not preclude both sides to opt for any other site with mutual consent," the bench added.

During the hearing, Ahmadi said that although an application had been made to the Collector for allotment of land, the authorities had identified a site that was not sufficiently close to the Bhojshala complex. He said the allotted site was around 1.3 km away by road and around 900 m away in terms of radius.

He said suitable Waqf plots adjacent to the Bhojshala complex were available and the state administration was denying them on the ground of law and order.

He referred to four possible locations around the complex, including dargah land adjoining the premises where Muslims can be allowed to offer Friday prayers.

"You can't yield to the wrongdoer," he submitted. The additional solicitor general said that the Government's concern was limited to maintaining law and order and that it was not seeking to enter into the competing claims of the parties.

HC asks Delhi Govt to study NH-48 drain feasibility

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi



The Delhi High Court has asked city authorities to examine the feasibility of constructing a storm water drain along the stretch of National Highway-48 between Mahipalpur and Rangpuri village here to prevent waterlogging.

Noting that the highway leads to Gurugram and is close to the IGI Airport, a bench of Justices Prathiba M Singh and Manmeet PS Arora directed the Special Task Force under Delhi Government chief secretary to hold a specific meeting on the issue and file a report after interacting with all stakeholders.

The stakeholders are Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi Development Authority, National Highways Authority of India, Delhi Jal Board, Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, and Public Works Department.

The bench said that if required, the task force would also interact with the GMR Group, which is part of the consortium that runs the Delhi airport. The court was hearing a petition by NGO Social Jurist seeking construction of a functional storm water drainage system along the stretch of NH-48 between Mahipalpur and Rangpuri village.

The petitioner showed pictures to the court to demonstrate how the area, including the Mahipalpur crossing, was getting submerged due to severe waterlogging during the rainy season.

Child pornography case: Delhi court says missing mobile can't shield accused from trial

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has upheld an order directing the framing of charges against a man accused of uploading child sexual abuse material on Facebook, saying that the non-recovery of the mobile phone allegedly used in the offence cannot be a ground to stifle a prosecution when digital evidence links the accused to the account.

Additional Sessions Judge Hargurvarinder Singh Jaggi was hearing a revision petition filed by Aditya Biswas, who challenged a trial court order directing framing of charges under Section 67B of the Information Technology Act against him.



The section deals with publishing or transmitting sexually explicit material involving children.

In the order dated July 27, the court said, "The physical recovery of a mobile phone is not an absolute sine qua non for framing a charge when the digital trail, particularly IP logs and subscriber data, securely links the transmission to the

accused's control over the social media account."

The case stems from an FIR registered by the South Delhi cyber police station in December 2022 following a complaint received from the National Crime Records Bureau based on a CyberTipline report generated by the US-based National Centre for Missing and Exploited Children (NCMEC).

According to the prosecution, a Facebook account named "Neem Biswas" uploaded a 17-second video depicting a child engaged in a sexually explicit act.

Investigators traced the account through an IP address and mobile number and alleged that Biswas had created and operated it using a friend's phone. The accused challenged the charge-framing order, arguing that no Facebook or NCMEC official had been examined, making the CyberTipline report inadmissible hearsay.

He also contended that no mobile phone was recovered from him and that the prosecution's case relied heavily on his disclosure statement.

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NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | JULY 31, 2026

BUSINESS11

Swiggy Q1 loss narrows to ₹791 crore

Food delivery and quick commerce major Swiggy on Thursday reported a net loss of ₹791 crore on a consolidated basis in the first quarter ended June 30, 2026. The company's net loss narrowed in Q1 FY27 from ₹1,197 crore a year ago, driven by strong revenue growth, according to a stock exchange filing.

During the quarter under review, Swiggy's revenue from operations increased to ₹6,812 crore, from ₹4,961 crore a year ago. Total expenses increased to ₹7,813 crore in the June quarter from ₹6,244 crore a year ago, driven by advertising and sales promotion, and delivery and related charges, among other costs.

In a letter to shareholders, Swiggy Co-founder, MD & Group CEO Sriharsha Majety said the company's quick commerce arm Instamart hit break-even contribution target in May 2026 with an overall contribution for the quarter at -0.2 per cent of gross order value (GOV), while Adjusted Ebitda losses for the segment narrowed to ₹778 crore.

Olectra Deploy Electric Buses on Haryana Roads

Olectra Greentech Limited, India's leading electric mobility company, has become the first company in India to deploy 4,000 electric buses on Indian roads. This landmark achievement marks a defining moment in the country's electric mobility journey and reinforces Olectra's leadership in accelerating India's transition towards sustainable public transportation.

The historic milestone was commemorated with the symbolic handover of Olectra's 4,000th electric bus to the Hon'ble Chief Minister of Himachal Pradesh Shri Sukhvinder Singh Sukhu & Mukesh Agnihotri, Hon'ble Deputy Chief Minister of Himachal Pradesh during the flag off ceremony of 297 Olectra electric buses inducted into the Himachal Road Transport Corporation (HRTC) fleet. Mahesh Babu, Managing Director, Olectra Greentech Ltd., said, "Today marks one of the proudest moments in Olectra's journey. Becoming the first company in India to deploy 4,000 electric buses on Indian roads is not just an Olectra milestone, it is a defining milestone for India's electric mobility industry."

M3M India to invest ₹600 cr to build commercial project in Gurugram

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Realty firm M3M India on Thursday said it will invest ₹600 crore to develop a commercial project in Gurugram.

In a statement, the company said it has launched a commercial project, "M3M Capital Financial Center".

M3M India said it will invest ₹600 crore to build this project, which is spread across 1.42 acres, comprising 165 units, including 152 premium office spaces, 6

multiplex units and 7 retail units.

The project, located at Sector 113, Dwarka

Expressway in Gurugram, is expected to be completed by 2029.

Gurugram-based M3M Group has two real estate companies - M3M India Pvt Ltd and Smartworld Developers Ltd. The Group develops residential, commercial and mixed-use projects in North India.

Earlier this month, M3M Group said it will invest ₹10,000 crore this financial year on construction and land acquisition as part of its expansion plan.

There is a comprehensive work plan under the India-EU free trade agreement to address concerns over the European Union's carbon tax, a senior government official said on Thursday, expressing hope that domestic small and medium enterprises will not face any problems due to that measure.

Additional Secretary in the Department of Commerce Darpan Jain said there are provisions, such as extension of flexibility to India by the EU, if the 27-nation bloc extends relaxation to other countries.

CBAM (carbon border adjustment mechanism) took a lot of negotiating capital. In the text, there is a separate Annexure on dealing with CBAM, and there are certain pillars. "The first pillar is that, in case of flexibility in future,

that will be available to India. So there is an obligation in that", he said.

"Second, CBAM compliances are a concern among SMEs in terms of verification, in terms of finding out what is the value of embedded carbon, in terms of ensuring that the verifiers are recognised by the EU authorities.

"So, there are separate provisions, and we also have a provision in which we can engage with EU authorities on taking into account the carbon price, which is paid in India. As you would know, India also is developing its own carbon pricing mechanism. So, how to offset what is paid in India from what is paid in Europe, so even that is part of it," Jain noted.

He was speaking at the IGCC (Indo-German Chamber of Commerce) Industry Dialogue 2026 here. He was replying to a question that MSMEs are apprehensive that

IRFC Q1 profit rises 10% to ₹1,927 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC) on Thursday reported a 10 per cent growth in net profit to ₹1,927 crore for the first quarter of the current financial year on improved core income.

The NBFC, under the administrative control of the Ministry of Railways, had earned a net profit of ₹1,746 crore in the year-ago period.

The company's total income rose to ₹8,391 crore in the April-June period from ₹6,918 crore a year ago, IRFC said in a regulatory filing.

However, the interest income declined to ₹1,148 crore as against ₹1,497 crore in the same period a year ago.

Lease income during the quarter improved to ₹7,094 crore from ₹5,404 crore in the year-ago period.

The total expenses of the Navratna

company during the period under review fell marginally to ₹6,464 crore from ₹5,173 crore in the corresponding period of FY25.

Net interest margin moderated to 1.48 per cent from 1.53 per cent in the

corresponding period of the previous financial year, it said.

"Q1 FY27 marks a strong start to the year with the Corporation delivering its highest-ever quarterly revenue, net worth and profitability. These results reaffirm the robustness of IRFC's diversification strategy under IRFC 2.0 and our continued discipline in maintaining a zero-NPA, high-quality asset book," Chairman and Managing Director Manoj Kumar Dubey said.

IRFC remains focused on deepening its presence across the mobility and other allied sectors having backward and forward linkage with railways in line with the whole-of-government approach, he added.

The company's net worth rose to a record ₹58,792 crore from ₹56,749 crore at the end of June 30, 2025.

Assets Under Management (AUM) stood at ₹4.79 lakh crore as on June 30, 2026, as against ₹4.85 lakh crore as on March 31, 2026, it said.

Maruti's Hansalpur facility becomes Suzuki's biggest production site globally

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki India on Thursday said its Hansalpur-based manufacturing facility in Gujarat has attained 10 lakh annual production capacity, making it Suzuki's largest passenger vehicle production site globally.

With the start of production at the fourth plant (Plant D) at Hansalpur, Maruti Suzuki's total manufacturing capacity across Haryana and Gujarat has risen to 29 lakh units per annum.

The auto major said it has cumulatively invested ₹25,288.7 crore on the 640-acre Hansalpur facility. This

includes an investment of around ₹3,900 crore on Plant D.

The new plant will initially produce the company's flagship Battery Electric Vehicle (BEV), e-Vitara.

Following the start of the fourth plant (Plant D) with an annual production capacity of 2.5 lakh units, the Hansalpur facility's total annual production capacity has increased to 10 lakh units annually from 7.5

lakh units, Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL) said in a statement.

"This marks the first time in Suzuki's history that the total annual production capacity at a single manufacturing facility has reached 1 million units," the company said.

It also makes Maruti Suzuki's Hansalpur plant India's largest passenger vehicle manufacturing facility at a single location, it added.

Commenting on the development, MSIL MD & CEO Hisashi Takeuchi said Gujarat has emerged as a manufacturing and export hub for Maruti Suzuki, backed by strong infrastructure and a progressive industrial ecosystem.

Stock markets end higher for 2nd day on FII inflows

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Benchmark equity indices Sensex and Nifty ended higher on Thursday, driven by a rally in blue-chip stocks Reliance Industries, HDFC Bank and foreign fund inflows.

In a volatile session, the 30-share BSE Sensex ended 273.55 points, or 0.35 per cent, higher at 77,928.15, helped by fag-end buying. During the day, it hit a high of 78,007.09 and a low of 77,440.91, gyrating 566.18 points.

The 50-share NSE Nifty advanced by 66.95 points, or 0.28 per cent, to end at 24,317.15.

From the Sensex pack, Maruti Suzuki, Mahindra & Mahindra, Reliance Industries, State Bank of India, HDFC Bank and Power Grid were among the major winners.

Adani Ports, InterGlobe Aviation, Bajaj Finserv and Bharat Electronics were among the laggards.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) bought equities worth ₹2,981.87 crore on Wednesday, according to

Lower taxes can unlock massive air travel demand, says IndiGo's Rahul Bhatia

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

IndiGo Managing Director Rahul Bhatia urged the government to cut taxes and rationalise airport charges, arguing that lower airfares would unlock "massive" demand in one of the world's fastest-growing aviation markets and accusing policymakers of taxing flying as if it were "an elitist mode of transport".

"On the one side, we say that flying by air has become a public utility, yet we treat taxes on it as if it's an elitist mode of transport," Bhatia told PTI in an interview.

"I think some of these

things have to get rationalised. Because the Indian consumer is so price sensitive that if you can lower fares, you just open up a massive demand."

Bhatia said airlines had largely absorbed cost pressures instead of passing them on to passengers.

"So, in a time span of three years where inflation has risen by 12 per cent, airfares, which represent the fares that the airline collects for themselves, have gone up between 1 per cent and 3 per cent. UDF (User Development Fee) charges at airports have gone up as much as 95 per cent.

"Landing and parking charges have gone up as

much as 34 per cent... airlines actually do their utmost to make sure that fares are competitive," he noted.

He said IndiGo, which controls 66.3 per cent of India's domestic market, had a responsibility to lead fare increases when surging costs made them unavoidable.

"I think the responsibility lies on IndiGo to lead the charge...if the fuel goes up 30 per cent and nobody raises fares, it's an excruciating pain for the industry," he said.

"And...if they don't, we'll go back and bring our fares down." Aviation turbine fuel accounts for around 40 per cent of airlines' operating costs, while carriers have also been

hit by higher oil prices and longer flying times because of airspace restrictions linked to the West Asia conflict."

IndiGo's best defence against fuel price volatility was operating increasingly fuel-efficient aircraft, Bhatia

said, adding that to the best of his knowledge, no Indian airline currently hedges fuel prices.

Responding to concerns over IndiGo's market dominance, Bhatia said about one-third of the airline's capacity was deployed on around 250 unique city pairs where it had created new markets.

"If 34 per cent of your share is in unique markets, our share in markets that we compete in is only just in the early 40s, 42, 44 per cent...So, I think it's a myth of sorts that we are too large," he said.

Airfares are not regulated by the government.

Airlines' operating costs are dynamic in nature, and their individual components vary due to multiple factors such as the price of Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) in international markets, foreign exchange rates, excise duties and Value Added Tax (VAT) and lease rentals.

In recent times, operating costs of airlines have sailed northwards due to a jump in oil prices and longer flying hours due to airspace curbs amid the West Asia conflict.

Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) or jet fuel alone accounts for around 40 per cent of an airline's operating expenses. The jet fuel is taxed at different rates by different states.

"Just because we consume so much ATF does not mean we are experts at determining what the Brent prices will be tomorrow morning. But our natural hedge today, to the extent possible, is obviously increasingly flying more and more fuel-efficient aircraft. So, if you fly planes that are 50 per cent more fuel-efficient, you have a hedge there.

"Currently, in India, to the best of my understanding, no other airline hedges. And then, of course, the fuel goes up. Then the other thing airlines try to do is start to raise fares to see how much of it will get absorbed by the consumers," Bhatia said.

districts and conduct outreach programmes there and tell industry about what is there in the FTA, how they can use it, how they can explore opportunities under that. We are also exploring other tools like electronic tools, so that we can engage with them, especially small businesses," he said.

Both sides in January announced the conclusion of talks for the pact. It is expected to be signed later this year and may come into force next year. Jain said the deal will provide huge business opportunities to both sides. India and the EU trade is about one-third of the global trade, which is about USD 33 trillion.

He said Germany is a powerhouse of auto, and its exports from the sector are about USD 286 billion, and the pact provides huge opportunities for the European country in India.

India's gold demand falls 6% in April-June

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

India's gold demand fell 6 per cent year-on-year to 131.4 tonnes in the April-June quarter, weighed down by seasonally subdued sales, higher Customs duty and Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal to reduce purchases of the precious metal, the World Gold Council said in a report.

The total demand was at 139.7 tonnes during the corresponding period last year, according to WGC's 'Q2 2026 Gold Demand Trends' report.

"However, it's been a record in terms of the value of demand. So, consumption was ₹1,98,100 crores, compared with ₹1,32,500 crores in the same period in 2025, which is up by 50 per cent compared to the second quarter of 2025, highlighting that consumers continue to prioritise gold even in a high-price environment," WGC Regional CEO, India, Sachin Jain told PTI.

Going forward, for the year, WGC estimated the

demand to stay between 650 and 750 tonnes. "We still see demand in the range of 650 to 750 tonnes for this year. However, given the current geopolitical landscape, interest rates, and inflation, I think we should be somewhere in the middle of this range. If there is more correction in gold prices and the customs duty is reduced, then we could get to the upper end of this range," Jain added.

Total jewellery demand in India during the quarter under review decreased by 15 per cent to 75.1 tonnes as compared to 88.8 tonnes in the same period last year.

"Subdued season, the clarion call of the Prime Minister to buy less gold and hike in Customs Duty, among others, impacted the demand," he added.

Prime Minister Modi, in May this year, urged people to reduce non-essential gold purchases and explore other ways to save foreign exchange reserves amid mounting import bills of the country due to volatile crude oil prices.

Ebola outbreak kills over 1,500 in Congo

PROSPER HERI NGORORA/ MARK BANCHEREAU ■ Bunia

The fastest-growing Ebola outbreak has killed more than 1,500 people in eastern Congo, official data released on Thursday showed, marking a 50 per cent increase in around a week that shows the emergency continuing to outpace response efforts.

As of Tuesday, 3,442 cases had been recorded, with 1,521 deaths, according to the latest Government update. The outbreak, which was declared on May 15, has been linked to the Bundibugyo virus, for which there is no approved vaccine or treatment.

There are currently 797 patients in isolation or hospitalised, while a further 615 patients have recovered, the data showed. Contact tracing continues to lag, with only



around 78 per cent of known contacts monitored nationwide, well below the 95 per cent target health officials say is needed to

interrupt transmission. The outbreak is mostly concentrated in eastern Congo's remote Ituri province, which accounts for

nearly 90 per cent of cases, but there have been other confirmed cases in five provinces, including one of the country's largest cities, Kisangani.

Neighbouring Uganda declared itself free of Ebola on Tuesday following the discharge of the country's last patient in mid-June. Ebola is rare, but highly contagious and can be contracted via bodily fluids such as vomit, blood or semen.

The disease it causes is severe and often fatal. The latest outbreak has killed more people at a quicker rate than any previous outbreak, including in 2014-2016, when 28,000 cases were reported, of which over 11,000 people died. That outbreak took about eight months to reach 1,000 deaths.

The speed of transmission in the current outbreak comes amid

public concern that many communities in the affected provinces are either unreachable or have been abandoned by responders in recent days over safety concerns amid attacks from angry residents and rebels.

International partners supporting the Ebola response in Ituri's Nyakunde health zone temporarily withdrew after a July 15 attack on a hospital and a treatment centre, sparked by a patient's death.

Officials say the withdrawal of aid groups, including the World Health Organisation, Africa CDC, Samaritan's Purse and Mercy Corps, has disrupted surveillance, contact tracing and supplies.

Local health officials say security has since stabilised and are urging partners to return, with Africa CDC saying teams could redeploy as soon as next week. (AP)

Turkish police detain Erdal Besikcioglu in latest raids



ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Istanbul

Police detained a former TV actor-turned-mayor on Thursday in the latest wave of arrests targeting the Opposition. Erdal Besikcioglu, the mayor of Etimesgut Municipality in western Ankara, is being investigated for allegations of irregularities and forgery in municipal tenders, the Justice Ministry said in a statement. Investigators are also examining parking lot leasing schemes and construction zoning permissions.

Besikcioglu played grizzled detective Behzat C in a popular police drama of the same name that ran from 2010 to 2019. He was elected mayor in 2024 with the opposition Republican People's Party, or CHP, in an

election where the opposition strengthened its grip on major cities, including Ankara and Istanbul.

Hundreds of elected mayors and other officials have been arrested in the past two years as part of criminal investigations, mostly into alleged corruption, in operations targeting opposition-run municipalities. Ekrem Imamoglu, the mayor of Istanbul, widely considered the strongest potential challenger to President Recep Tayyip Erdogan, has also been arrested and imprisoned since March last year. He faces criminal cases that could result in decades-long sentences. Erdogan's Government insists that Turkey's courts are impartial and act independently of political pressure.

Pakistan is trying to bring US and Iran back to negotiating table: Foreign Office

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Islamabad

Pakistan on Thursday said it was "doing its utmost" to bring the US and Iran back to the negotiating table under the Islamabad memorandum of understanding (MoU) signed last month, amid escalating tensions in the region.

"We support dialogue and diplomacy as they are the only viable path forward," Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi said at his weekly press briefing here.

Andrabi said Pakistan was "doing its utmost" to revive negotiations between Washington and Tehran and resolve outstanding issues in the spirit of the Islamabad MoU and the Pakistan-Qatar joint statement of June 22. He said Pakistan remained concerned over the precarious security situation in the Middle East despite a relative lull in hostilities over the past few days.



Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi

He said the pause had raised hopes that the positive development would lead to a durable and fully respected ceasefire and ultimately pave the way for the resumption of dialogue.

Militants attack security checkpoint in Pakistan, 9 policemen killed

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

At least nine policemen, including a senior officer, were killed and over two dozen others injured when militants attacked a checkpoint in northwest Pakistan, police said on Thursday.

The attack late Wednesday on the Khazina Banda checkpoint in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa's Hangu district, bordering Afghanistan, also left 15 militants dead, police said.

No group or individual immediately claimed responsibility for the attack. Inspector General of Police



Zulfiqar Hameed said that the checkpoint was attacked by Fitna al Khawarij, a term the Government uses for the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) terrorists. Following the attack on the police checkpoint, reinforcements were dispatched to assist, he said.

However, the vehicle carrying additional personnel also came under fire, he added. During the intense exchange of fire, nine policemen, including Deputy Superintendent of Police Diyar Khan, were killed while 28 others were injured, Hameed said. He added that 15 militants were killed while multiple others were injured due to the police's response.

Speaking to Dawn, a senior police official also confirmed the number of casualties. He said that an exchange of fire broke out after the terrorists attacked the checkpoint.

Turkey wants to join a new Lebanon security initiative after UN mission ends

SUZAN FRASER/ABBY SEWELL ■ Ankara

Turkiye is interested in participating in a new security initiative for Lebanon when the 7,500-member UN peacekeeping mission in the south of the country expires at the end of the year, Turkish President Recep Tayyip Erdogan said during a joint press statement with his Lebanese counterpart on Thursday.

Last year, the UN Security Council voted unanimously to terminate the peacekeeping mission known as UNIFIL, bowing to demands from the United States and its close ally, Israel. The UN is now considering options to help end the decades-old conflict between Lebanon's Iran-backed Hezbollah militants and Israel. "After the withdrawal of the current international force, Turkiye wants to take part in all initiatives that will be launched to support security in the region and ensure Lebanon's sovereignty," Erdogan said, speaking alongside Lebanese President Joseph Aoun.

"The end of the mandate of the United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon, UNIFIL, deployed in southern Lebanon,



will constitute an important development," Erdogan stated. Other countries have voiced an interest in contributing to a UNIFIL successor force, including France and Italy, but it remains unclear what form that force might take and whether it would be under a UN mandate or some other arrangement.

Aoun's visit to Ankara comes as Lebanon remains in a precarious situation despite a shaky truce that has largely halted the fighting between Israel and Hezbollah.

The latest Israel-Hezbollah war began on March 2 when Hezbollah launched rockets across the border, days after the US and Israel attacked Iran, triggering an ongoing regional war. More than 4,000

people have been killed in Lebanon, including hundreds of civilians, and hundreds of thousands displaced. While the fighting has largely cooled in recent weeks, Israeli troops continue to occupy large swaths of southern Lebanon.

On June 26, Israel and Lebanon reached a US-mediated "framework agreement" under which Israeli forces are to withdraw from areas of southern Lebanon they are occupying in exchange for the disarmament of the Hezbollah militant group.

Aoun said he wants to see the relations between the two countries become "more present and more ambitious" at a "crucial moment in which we are restoring our region and reshaping its future."

84,000 evacuees return home as France fire eases

MARK CARLSON/ALEX TURNBULL/ JOHN LEICESTER ■ Lege-Cap Ferret

French authorities gave the go-ahead Thursday for 84,000 evacuees forced out by a monster wildfire to go back to their homes in southwest France, the strongest sign yet that firefighters are turning a corner in their battle against the flames that have burned an area four times the size of Paris.

Europe is enduring one of its hottest summers on record, with wildfires breaking out in areas stretching from the Atlantic coast to the eastern Mediterranean, and hundreds of thousands of people ordered to evacuate from homes and vacation destinations.

Firefighters fanned out to battle infernos in places like England, Spain, and Turkiye, while in Romania, officials at the state-owned Cernavoda nuclear power plant shut down both of its reactors because of the low level of Danube River waters used to cool them.

The returns authorised in France covered nine localities that had been evacuated, including several where firefighters and water-dropping planes had battled flare-ups just the day before. Higher humidity, cooler temperatures and slight rain have raised hopes that Thursday could be a decisive step on the way to vanquishing the fire.

"We're on the right track," said Sophie Brocas, prefect of the Gironde region, which includes the city of Bordeaux.

Nearly two-thirds of the 224,000 people



initially ordered to evacuate their homes in southwest France have now been allowed to go home. Some 60,000 people who had been evacuated from three Bordeaux suburbs were given the go-ahead to return on Tuesday. Evacuees immediately streamed back Thursday to the emptied towns and villages, among them 50-year-old Sanachit Pho Ne Keo and his wife. They were relieved to discover that apart from black ash on an outside terrace, their home in Martignas-sur-Jalle hadn't been damaged or looted. "Everything seems OK, and it's a good feeling!" he said. "The fire was pretty close; the last smoking embers are still close... but we could've expected worse."

Local officials reported a "rather calm" night, with a fire that has not grown beyond the 42,000 hectares (about 162 sq. miles) already affected. Some expressed hope that hard-hit businesses could soon get back to work.

The regional prefecture said returning evacuees must keep their phones on for evacuation alerts and should pack in case they need to leave again. (AP)

Malaysia starts screening detained Myanmar citizens

EILEEN NG ■ Kuala Lumpur

Malaysia has started documenting and screening thousands of detained Myanmar nationals as part of a repatriation program agreed with Myanmar, Home Minister Saifuddin Nasution said on Thursday.

Saifuddin said Myanmar had committed to accept up to 5,000 of its citizens currently living in Malaysia and an unspecified number currently in Cox's Bazar, a town in south east Bangladesh. Malaysia had identified up to 4,000 Myanmar nationals in its 19 detention depots, who will be moved to a single site for security screening and documentation purposes, he said.

"We will certainly meet the target of 5,000 individuals once this process is complete," Saifuddin told to reporters, adding that the foreign ministry will handle the next stage of the repatriation process with Myanmar.

Prime Minister Anwar Ibrahim had said Wednesday that those being repatriated were Rohingya refugees.

"People ask why we do not simply send them back. Send them where? Myanmar had refused to accept them before. Now, because of our good relations with Myanmar, they have agreed to take back 5,000 from Malaysia," Anwar was cited as saying by the New Straits Times. However, Saifuddin, who did not explicitly identify the 5,000 individuals as Rohingya,



said only Myanmar nationals with refugee status were being repatriated.

Foreign ministry officials could not be immediately reached for comment.

Mohammed Mizanur Rahman, a commissioner for refugee, relief and repatriation in Cox's Bazar, told The Associated Press by phone that he was not aware of any repatriation of Rohingyas from Bangladesh. In Naypyitaw, the capital of Myanmar, officials also rejected reports that the Government would accept Rohingyas. Han Win Aung, director-general of the ASEAN department at Myanmar's Foreign Affairs Ministry, said the repatriation program was focused solely on verified Myanmar nationals currently held in detention centres in Malaysia. (AP)



सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

1911 से आपके लिए "सेन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

BRANCH OFFICE: BULANDSHAHR ROAD INDUSTRIAL AREA, GHAZIABAD, U.P.

DEMAND NOTICE 13(2) OF SECURITISATION ACT 2002

Demand Notice Under Section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest (SARFAESI) Act, 2002 to the Borrower /s and Guarantor /s.
This Demand Notice is hereby given under section 13(2) of the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) read with rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 hereinafter calling upon the under mentioned Borrowers / Guarantors to repay, the Amounts outstanding for the Credit Facilities granted to them / on their Guarantee, within 60 days from the date of this Notice. If you fail to repay to the Bank the below mentioned amount with further interest and incidental expenses, costs etc. in terms of this notice u/s 13(2) of the Act, the Bank will exercise all or any of the rights detailed under Sub-Section (4) of Section 13 and under other applicable provisions of the said Act. You are also put on notice that in terms of sub-section 4 of Section 13 you shall not transfer by sale, lease or otherwise the said secured assets detailed below of this notice without obtaining written consent of the Bank.
The details of the account and Secured Assets along with Amount Outstanding is given below:-
SCHEDULE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY & OTHER DETAILS

Name & Address of Borrower and Guarantor	Description of the Secured Asset	Date & Amount of 13(2) Notice
BORROWER: MR. RAJU KUMAR S/O RAM CHANDER MR. VIPIN KUMAR GARG House No.4, Upper Ground Floor Plot No. T 164A, TBlock Uttam Nagar, Delhi-110034. GUARANTOR: MS. SUSHMA D/O MR. NAHAR SINGH RZ-195, 8 Deep Enclave Hastal JJ Colony, Delhi-110059.	Immovable Property: Equitable Mortgage of Residential Built up Upper Ground Floor, Flat No.4, Plot No.164A, Back Side RHS Without Roof / Terrace Rights, T Block, Uttam Nagar, Delhi-110059, Admeasuring Area 70 Sq.Yards, vide deposit of Sale Deed No.11138 dated 19/05/2022 which was duly registered in the office of Sub-Registrar SR IIB Janakpuri, New Delhi, Book No.1, Volume - 7559, Page No.10 to 19, Owned by Mr. Raju Kumar. Bounded By: South: Gali 10' Ft Wide East: Entry and Flat No.03 West: Other Property North: Lift and Flat No.1	Date of 13(2) Notice: 16.07.2026 N.P.A. Date: 20.03.2026 Rs.32,39,476.76 (Rupees Thirty Two Lakh Thirty Nine Thousand Four Hundred Seventy Six and Seventy Six Paise Only) plus future Interest at the applicable rate/s of interest mentioned in the Schedule A from the date of notice 16/07/2026 till the date of full and final payment along with incidental expenses, charges and costs recoverable from you as per terms of contract and/or as per law, within sixty days from the date of this notice.

YOUR ATTENTION IS DRAWN TO THE PROVISIONS OF SECTION 13(8) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002 IN RESPECT OF TIME AVAILABLE TO YOU TO REDEEM THE SECURED ASSETS.
ALL OUR PREVIOUS 13(2) DEMAND NOTICES ISSUED UNDER SECTION 13(2) OF THE SARFAESI ACT, 2002 STANDS WITHDRAWN
DATE: 30.07.2026
PLACE: GHAZIABAD, U.P.

Sd/- Authorised Officer,
Central Bank of India



सेन्ट्रल बैंक ऑफ इंडिया
Central Bank of India

1911 से आपके लिए "सेन्ट्रल" "CENTRAL" TO YOU SINCE 1911

BRANCH OFFICE: KASHMERE GATE, DELHI-110006

POSSESSION NOTICE (For Immovable Property)
[Under Rule 8(4) of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002]

Whereas, the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of the Central Bank of India, Kashmere Gate Branch, Delhi under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act 2002, and in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(2) and 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued a Demand Notice dated 22.05.2026, Calling upon the Borrower: MS. DEEPIKA GUPTA D/O SH. SURESH GUPTA, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice being Rs.52,32,871.78 (Rupees Fifty Two Lakh Thirty Two Thousand Eight Hundred Seventy One and Seventy Eight Paise Only) (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 21.05.2026), plus interest and other charges from 22.05.2026 to till date within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrower having failed to pay the entire dues of the bank, notice is hereby given to the borrower, the Guarantor and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rule 2002 on this 30th Day of July 2026.
The borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealing with the property will be subject to the charge of the Central Bank of India, Kashmere Gate Branch, Delhi for the amount of Rs.52,32,871.78 (Rupees Fifty Two Lakh Thirty Two Thousand Eight Hundred Seventy One and Seventy Eight Paise Only) (which represents the principal plus interest due as on the 21.05.2026), plus interest and other charges from 22.05.2026.
The borrower's attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section (13) of the SARFAESI Act, in respect of the time available, to redeem the secured assets.
DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
RZ-F1/136A, 2nd Floor without Roof Rights, Area Measuring 78 Sq.Yds. i.e. 62.2158 Sq.Mtr. out of Khassra No.88/3, situated in the Revenue Estate of Village Palam, Delhi State Delhi Colony Known as Mahavir Enclave, New Delhi-110045.
Owner - Ms. Deepika Gupta D/o Sh. Suresh Gupta. Bounded By:
East: Property No.RZ-F-1/136B
West: Property No.RZ-F-1/135
North: Other's Property
South: Road 20 Ft

PLACE: NEW DELHI
DATE: 30/07/2026

(Authorised Officer),
Central Bank of India, Kashmere Gate Branch

Sainik Welfare, Assam contributes ₹25 lakh to CM’s relief fund

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

In a significant gesture of solidarity and public service, the Directorate of Sainik Welfare, Assam has contributed ₹25 lakh to the Chief Minister's Relief Fund to support ongoing relief and rehabilitation efforts across the State of Assam, especially for those affected by the recent devastating floods in Upper Assam. The contribution reflects the veterans' fraternity of Assam's continued commitment to serving society even after their years of distinguished service in the armed forces. Brig Polash Chowdhury, SM (Retd), Director, Directorate of Sainik Welfare, Assam, along with Air Marshal Anjan Kumar Gogoi, PVSM, AVSM, VSM (Retd) and Asom Baibhav, Lt Gen Rana Pratap Kalita, PVSM, UYSM, AVSM, SM, VSM (Retd) of the veterans' fraternity of Assam, presented the cheque to the Chief Minister of Assam, Himanta



Biswa Sarma, reaffirming their dedication to the welfare and development of the people of the State. Speaking on the occasion, Brig Polash Chowdhury, SM (Retd), stated that the donation is a symbol of their enduring sense of duty and their desire to stand with the people of Assam during such adverse climatic conditions. He expressed confidence that the Chief

Minister's Relief Fund would ensure assistance reaches those who need it the most. The Director also mentioned that a large number of ex-servicemen from Assam have been voluntarily involved in relief efforts along with the civil administration of the state. The Chief Minister thanked the veterans of Assam for their generous contribution and appreciated their unwavering spirit of patriotism,

service and compassion. He noted that their gesture would inspire others to contribute towards humanitarian and relief initiatives in the State of Assam. The veterans of Assam reiterated their commitment to supporting such noble initiatives that promote public welfare, disaster relief, community development and continuing their tradition of selfless service to the nation.

11th All India Police Judo Cluster Championship 2026 concludes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

The 11th All India Police Judo Cluster Championship 2026, hosted by the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) under the aegis of the All India Police Sports Control Board (AIPSCB), concluded on Friday with a closing ceremony held at the GMC Balayogi Indoor Stadium, Gachibowli and Hyderabad. The ceremony was graced by CV Anand, IPS, Director General of Police (HoPF), Telangana, as the chief guest, along with Vijay Prakash, IPS, ADG/HQrs, CISF, Sambandan S IPS (representing DIB), Harpreet Kaur, (Director, NISA, Hyderabad), AIPSCB officials, State dignitaries, and members of the media.

As per the points system, Sashastra Seema Bal (SSB) emerged as the overall champions with 24 Gold, 20 Silver and 23 Bronze medals, thereby securing 203 points. CISF secured the Runners-up position with 25 Gold, 16 Silver and 25 Bronze medals (total 198 points), while Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) finished third with 10 Gold, 21 Silver and 26 Bronze medals (139 points).

The championship saw competition across five disciplines, the results of which are as follows: Judo — Champions: SSB; Runners-up: BSF; Third: Uttar Pradesh Police; Wushu — Champions: SSB; Runners-up: CRPF; Third: ITBP; Taekwondo (Men) — Champions: CISF; Runners-up: BSF; Third: Uttar Pradesh Police. Taekwondo (Women) — Champions: Uttar Pradesh Police; Runners-



up: CISF; Third: Assam Rifles; Pencak Silat — Champions: CISF; Runners-up: SSB; Third: Maharashtra ND and Karate — Champions: Assam Rifles; Runners-up: ITBP; Third: CISF. Speaking on the occasion, Vijay Prakash, IPS, ADG/HQrs, CISF, congratulated all the winning teams and medalists, and encouraged athletes who did not win a medal to treat the experience as a foundation for future success.

GAIL (India) Limited enters FTSE4Good Index Series



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

GAIL (India) Limited, India's integrated energy major, has entered the globally recognised FTSE4Good Index Series. The company has been awarded the FTSE4Good Index Certificate of Membership, following the June 2026 review by FTSE Russell. The recognition underscores GAIL's unwavering commitment to maintaining high standards of Environmental, Social and Governance (ESG) performance. It reflects the company's continued focus on environmental stewardship, social responsibility

Haryana CM attends sports, fitness expo in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that Haryana has emerged as the sports powerhouse of the country. Although Haryana accounts for only 2 per cent of the country's population, the largest number of medal-winning athletes in the Olympics, Paralympics, Asian Games and Commonwealth Games are from the State, bringing laurels to both Haryana and the nation. The CM was addressing the gathering at the Sports, Fitness and Infrastructure Expo organised at Bharat Mandapam, New Delhi, on Thursday. Union Minister for Youth Affairs and Sports Mansukh Mandaviya attended the event as the chief guest.

Addressing the gathering, Nayab Singh Saini said that the event was not merely an exhibition but a confluence of dreams and aspirations, where the immense potential of the country's youth could be witnessed. He said that Prime Minister Narendra Modi has given a new direction and a distinct identity to sports in the country. Initiatives such as Fit India and Khelo India have transformed sports from being merely a competition into a movement for nation-building.

Haryana leads the medal tally: The Chief Minister said that Haryana reflects not only a vibrant sporting culture but also a clear vision that has transformed this small State into India's greatest sporting power.



While Haryana accounts for only 2 per cent of the country's population, it stands at the forefront whenever medals are counted.

Cash awards of up to ₹6 crore for medal winners: The Chief Minister said that the Haryana Government is providing cash awards of up to ₹6 crore to sportspersons winning gold medals in the Olympic Games, Asian Games and Commonwealth Games. He said that during the last 12 years, ₹730 crore has been transferred directly into the bank accounts of 17,182 sportspersons. Saini said that the State Government has made a provision to provide a monthly scholarship of ₹1,500 to players in the 8 to 14 years age group, while players in the 15 to 19 years age group are being provided a monthly scholarship of ₹2,000.

Chief Minister motivates sportspersons : Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini urged sportspersons not to be discouraged by defeat or carried away by victory.

He encouraged them to become better with each passing day, saying that while medals are a recognition of hard work, the ultimate goal of every true sportsperson should be to bring glory to the nation. Delhi Home, Education and Sports Minister, Ashish Sood; Bihar Sports Minister, Shreyasi Singh, Haryana Sports Minister, Gaurav Gautam, Director General, Information, Public Relations and Languages Department, Haryana, K Makrand Pandurang and other distinguished dignitaries also remained present on the occasion.

Paresh Ranpara takes over as Director (Personnel), NHPC Ltd

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Paresh Ranpara has assumed charge as Director (Personnel) of NHPC Limited, a premier Navratna Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Power, Government of India, on 30 July 2026. Before he was appointed Director (Personnel), NHPC, Ranpara was serving as Director (Human Resources) at Grid-India, where he was responsible for providing strategic leadership in human resource management, talent development, organisational capability building and workforce planning. Ranpara is a human resource professional with over 31 years of rich experience in the power sector, spanning both public and private organisations. He holds a Master of Social Work (MSW) from The Maharaja Sayajirao University of Baroda and a Bachelor of Business Administration (BBA) from Sardar Patel University. He is



also a Certified Assessor from XLRI, Jamshedpur. In Grid-India, Ranpara placed strategic emphasis on Learning & Development by building partnerships with reputed institutions and strengthening capability frameworks. To ensure long-term leadership continuity, Ranpara successfully implemented succession planning initiatives anchored in competency frameworks. Before joining Grid-India, Ranpara served as head of Human Resources at Gujarat Urja Vikas Nigam Limited (GUVNL), where he was responsible for formulating HR policies for the GUVNL group com-

prising over 60,000 employees. During his tenure, he played a pivotal role in the successful unbundling of the erstwhile Gujarat Electricity Board (GEB) by leading the organisational change management and communication process. As Director (Personnel), NHPC Limited, Ranpara will provide strategic direction to the Company's human resource functions. His responsibilities will encompass human resource planning, talent management, organisational development, industrial relations, learning and development, employee engagement, and other key personnel-related functions.

DAILY SUDOKU

1				7	4	9		
				3	1		5	
7	5				9			6
					2			1
	9						7	
5			7					
8			3				6	4
	6		2	4				
		7	9	8				5

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

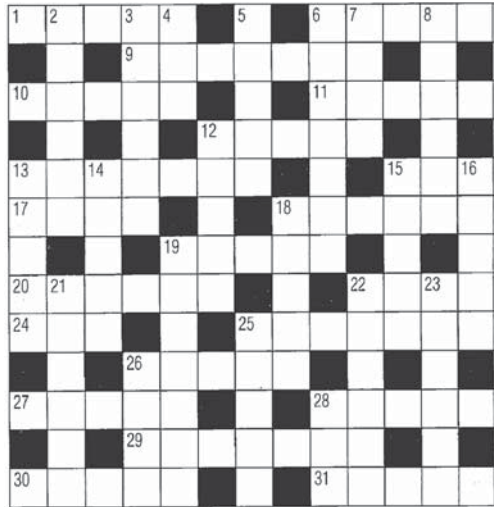
Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (30.7.26)

6	4	9	7	5	2	8	1	3
5	2	7	3	1	8	4	6	9
8	3	1	4	9	6	2	7	5
9	6	5	2	4	3	7	8	1
4	8	3	1	7	5	9	2	6
7	1	2	6	8	9	5	3	4
1	5	8	9	3	7	6	4	2
2	7	4	5	6	1	3	9	8
3	9	6	8	2	4	1	5	7

DOUBLE CROSSWORD FRIDAY | JULY 31, 2026



ACROSS

- Possibly put on in a London park (5)
- Passes over sporting leaders, in short (5)
- A few words or couple of letters making a point, cleverly (7)
- Girl's name for a French city (5)
- Change from green to red, maybe (5)
- Come out with a burst of speed (5)
- Loud noises from pufflers (7)
- Sibilant little sibling (3)
- Prepare less than expeditiously (4)
- Tease a companion for a sign of restlessness (6)
- Where frogs' legs may be eaten in pairs (5)

DOWN

- Covered with extremes of peril on the wrong date (6)
- Mysterious officer heading a sect (6)
- No it's less than ten a year (3)
- Walks up and down? (5)
- Thus growl, love, at points of sadness (7)
- Use needles to a possibly comforting end (4)
- Sort of licence one needs to write verse? (6)
- No such thing as a piece of cake! (5)
- A place to comb when stranded? (5)
- Wrong use of words (5)
- Drunken sot, I see, showing little

- Faith in direct action (6)
- In business, one is not soft (4)
- Is he half cut? (3)
- Wherein rushing water cuts round a bend? (7)
- Crept out of hotels without finishing lunch (5)
- Irrational devotion to a mere craze (5)
- Judged to interfere with trade (5)
- One advising a priest, perhaps, on central heating (7)
- Flat enterable from front or rear (5)
- Aliens from the ends of the earth (5)

emotion (5)

- Amid hisses, a bad actor simulates (5)
- A name one may fight for (5)
- Beastly end for a man to have? (7)
- Have a grave effect upon (6)
- Character playing a big part in a gambling game (6)
- In Congress, readers, you'll find a hero named Paul (6)
- Cut a corner in a window frame (5)
- Locate with sound sense (4)
- Bit of a square peg, this salesman? (3)

IRFC reports best-ever quarterly performance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC), a Navratna Central Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Railways, today announced its unaudited financial results (standalone) for the first quarter ended



30th June 2026 (Q1 FY 2026-27). Commenting on the results, Manoj Kumar Dubey, Chairman and Managing Director of IRFC, said, "Q1 FY 2026-27 marks a strong start to the year. The Corporation delivered its highest-ever quarterly revenue. Net worth and profitability. These results reaffirm the

robustness of IRFC's diversification strategy under IRFC 2.0 and our continued discipline in maintaining a zero-NPA, high-quality asset book. As we build on the momentum from FY 2025-26, we remain focused on deepening our presence across the mobility and other allied sectors.

VIT-AP excels at National Taekwondo Championship



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Amaravati

VIT-AP University is proud to announce the outstanding achievements of its student-athletes, who have once again brought glory to the University through their exceptional performances in national and State-level sporting events.

At the VIFA South Zone Taekwondo Championship, held at the Gundu Rao Sports Complex, Malleswaram, Bengaluru, from July 25 to 27, 2026, VIT-AP students delivered remarkable performances, securing four medals at the national level.

GS Diwakar (23MIS7314), a student of the University, showcased exceptional skill and determination by winning gold medal in indi-

vidual recognised Poomsae, silver medal in Kyorugi (under 85 kg category), Arya Pratap (24BCA7093) also delivered an outstanding performance, earning gold Medal in Kyorugi (Above 85 kg category) and silver medal in individual recognised Poomsae.

Adding to the university's sporting accomplishments, VIT-AP students performed commendably at the State-level Chess Tournament, organised at Scotpine International School, Kanuru, Vijayawada, on July 26, 2026. The University's chess players secured the following positions: Peeyush Kumar Jeena (25BCA7243) — 6th place, RV Bhagatheeswar Reddy (25BCE8773) — 7th place and Ashwin T (24BCE8059) — 10th place

Haryana minister grants ₹21 lakh to Gurjar Bhawan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kaithal

On the occasion of the 13th Foundation Day of Gurjar Bhawan, a grand function was organised by the community at the Gurjar Dharamshala. Haryana Minister of State Rajesh Nagar attended the event as the chief guest and announced a grant of ₹21 lakh from his discretionary fund for construction work at the dharamshala. He also laid the foundation stone for another construction project worth ₹21 lakh, to be undertaken by the Municipal Council.

The minister was welcomed by BJP district president Jyoti Saini and representatives of the Gurjar community. Addressing the gathering, Rajesh Nagar said that the newly developed infrastructure would provide better facilities for social, cultural, and educational activities, giving a new direction to the functioning of Gurjar Bhawan. Appreciating the quality of the dharamshala, he described it as one of the finest community buildings. He urged members of the community to prioritise their children's education, emphasising that sustainable development is possible only through education.



Minister Rajesh Nagar

Nagar stated that under the leadership of Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini, the Haryana Government is working for the welfare of every section of society. He highlighted that young people are now securing Government jobs on merit, without the need for recommendations or bribery, and encouraged students to focus on their education to build a secure future. Former Minister Kanwar Pal Gurjar also addressed the gathering, emphasising the importance of community unity. He said that institutions such as Gurjar Bhawan would play a significant role in the overall development of the community. Former MLA Leela Ram and Chairman of the Livestock Development Board Ashok Sirsi also present on the occasion.

BRIEFLY

Indian men enter semifinals in World Squash Junior title



The fifth seed Indian men's team progressed to the semifinals with a victory over England but the women's side crashed out of the competition after losing to USA in the World Squash Junior Team Championships here.

The Indian men's team beat third seed England to set up a semifinal clash against USA as it took to better its bronze medal-finish last year in this event.

AryaveerDewan put India ahead with a 3-0 win over Ronnie Hickling but England levelled the scores after Ismail Khalil beat YushaNafees 3-0.

India's Gurveer Singh clinched the decider with a win in straight games over George Griffiths.

The recently-crowned world junior women's champion Anahat Singh gave India a winning start, defeating Diya Yadav 3-0 in the women's quarterfinal.

However, USA staged a comeback as India's Rudra Singh lost to Charlotte Sze 1-2 and Anika Dubey lost to Lily Bourell 1-2 in the next two matches to make their place in the semifinals.

Results (quarterfinals): Men: India bt England 2-1 Women: India lost to USA 1-2

(PTI)

Cape Verde WC star Vozinha dons Spider-Man jersey



Vozinha is cashing in on his newfound fame by promoting the new Spider-Man film. The 40-year-old World Cup star's arrival to his new club in Chile, however, was caught up in old-fashioned paperwork.

The Cape Verde goalkeeper was scheduled to be with Colo Colo by Wednesday, but Chile's biggest and most successful club says Vozinha's trip has been delayed because of paperwork. They're hopeful of a Thursday arrival.

Vozinha was still able to wear a jersey Wednesday though - by donning Spider-Man gear as part of a Sony Pictures Brazil campaign promoting "Spider-Man: Brand New Day."

On Instagram, Vozinha encouraged his 29.6 million followers - up from under 50,000 before the World Cup - to go see the film.

Meanwhile, Colo Colo is also racing to resolve some issues regarding Vozinha. The most pressing concern is the name that will appear on the goalkeeper's jersey.

(AP)

Neeraj, Rohit and Yashvir enter CWG javelin final

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Glasgow

Olympic hero Neeraj Chopra, along with two other Indians, advanced to the Commonwealth Games men's javelin throw final after finishing among the top 12 in the qualification round as strong, shifting winds foiled every athlete's attempt to achieve the automatic qualifying mark here on Thursday.

Chopra, who won the javelin throw title in 2018, was fifth with a best effort of 79.61m, while Rohit Yadav (78.37m) and Yashvir Singh (78.36m) ended the qualification in ninth and 10th positions respectively to ensure a full Indian contingent in the medal round.

The 28-year-old Chopra, who was the last thrower in each round, did not take his third and final attempt as he had already made it to the final by that time.

With a steady headwind and a temperature of 18 degree Celsius making conditions difficult throughout the event, none of the competitors was able to breach the automatic



qualification mark of 84m, leaving the top 12 athletes to progress to the final round to be held on Friday.

"The conditions were not the best for javelin throwers. It was not only cold but also windy. And the wind was

coming from all directions ... it was really hard to assess which side it will come from. And lots of throwers were struggling today, no automatic qualification," Chopra told reporters after the event.



"It was difficult to keep ourself warm also. We were trying to understand the conditions during the warm up throws but nobody was able to decode. The athletes put in a lot of effort but the wind dictated terms. A lot of them will be unhappy today because I dont think anyone would be satisfied with their throw," Chopra added.

Only four competitors could breach the 80m mark.

Sri Lanka's in-form Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage, winner of the Doha and Rome Diamond League meetings this season, topped the

qualification with a first-round throw of 82.84m. Last edition silver winner Anderson Peters of Grenada was second with a best throw of 81.29m.

"I am really happy that I qualified and I will try for gold tomorrow. This seems to be my luck year," Pathirage said.

Paris Olympics gold medallist and defending champion Arshad Nadeem (78.63m) of Pakistan and reigning world champion Keshorn Walcott (78.26m) of Trinidad and Tobago also made it to the finals after finishing seventh and 11th respectively.

Kenya's Julius Yego, who won a

gold in the 2014 edition and a bronze in 2022 Birmingham Games, failed to make the grade after finishing 13th with 74.50m.

Sporting a beanie in the chilly Glasgow weather, Chopra drew the loudest cheers from the crowd at the picturesque Scotstoun Stadium but took a measured approach in testing conditions.

The former world champion opened with a modest 76.28m, which placed him sixth after the first round. He improved to 79.61m with his second effort to move up to fifth. He chose not to take his last attempt.

"I am happy that I qualified, it was really cold and windy. 79m throw was ok, the goal was to qualify for the final and do well there," Chopra said.

Yashvir, whose season and personal best is 83.72m, also built steadily through the competition. The 24-year-old opened with 73.89m, improved to 74.45m in the second round and then registered 78.36m with his final attempt to seal qualification.

Rohit, who has a season and personal best of 87.05m, began with a throw of 77.04m before improving to 78.37m in his second attempt. He also chose not to take the final attempt.

Chopra has returned from a lower back injury that has troubled him since September last year. The injury delayed his return until the Doha Diamond League in June, where he finished fourth with 85.69m, below his usual lofty standards.

(PTI)

Martina's CWG debut ends in tears, finishes 5th in +86kg weight class

APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Glasgow

Two tearful walks off the platform summed up Martina Devi's heartbreaking Commonwealth Games debut as the Indian super-heavyweight lifter fought back from the brink of elimination before falling agonisingly short of a medal to finish fifth in the women's +86kg competition here on Thursday.

The 18-year-old from Manipur registered a total lift of 245kg (105kg snatch + 140kg clean and jerk), the same as New Zealand's Tui-Alofa Patolo (115kg + 130kg).

However, Patolo claimed fourth place on the basis of fewer failed attempts.

England's two-time Olympic medallist Emily Campbell successfully defended her title in dominant fashion, shattering the Commonwealth and Games clean and jerk record en



India's Maibam Martina Devi competes in the Women's +86kg weightlifting event during the Commonwealth Games 2026 in Glasgow, Scotland

PTI

route to gold with a total of 278kg (115kg + 163kg).

Malaysia's Siti Aqilah Farhana Draman took silver with 253kg (113kg + 140kg), while Canada's Etta Mae Love secured bronze with 250kg (106kg + 144kg).

Martina's campaign began nervously as she

failed her opening two snatch attempts at 103kg, suddenly finding herself on the brink of elimination.

In a bold tactical call, head coach Vijay Sharma increased the weight to 105kg for her final attempt instead of repeating 103kg. The gamble paid off spectac-

ularly as Martina produced a clean lift with remarkable ease, displaying impressive composure under immense pressure to stay alive in the competition.

The relief was overwhelming. As she walked backstage, the teenager broke down in tears after surviving the biggest scare of her competition.

The Indian think tank then set an entry weight in her clean and jerk at 140kg, the second-highest declared opening weight in the field, and Martina completed it comfortably on her first attempt.

Needing bigger lifts to force her way into the medals, she called for 144kg in her second attempt but could not complete it.

Her final effort at 146kg also ended in disappointment, bringing her campaign to a tearful close as she walked off the platform.

(PTI)

Para CWG: Gold, silver finish for India in 100m T47



APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Glasgow

India's para-athletes remained an inspiring and unstoppable force at the Commonwealth Games as sprinters Dilip Mahadur Gavit and Mohammed Basil scripted another story of grit with a gold-silver finish in the men's 100m T47 final in Glasgow.

Gavit clocked a Games record and his season's best time of 10.71 seconds to take the top spot, while Basil produced his season's best of 10.83 seconds to finish second in a closely-fought race on Wednesday.

England's Kevin Santos completed the podium taking 10.85 seconds to win bronze. The men's 100m T47 is a para athletics sprint event covers arm impairment or absence, affecting strength, movement or coordination on one side.

Gavit's gold was India's third at the Games, following MirabaiChanu's victory in the women's 48kg weightlifting event and SharmilaDhankar's triumph in the women's shot put F57 para athletics category.

The 40-year-old Sharmila, who was afflicted with Polio at two years of age, survived the trauma of an abusive marriage to come this far.

Behind Gavit's gold medal lies a journey shaped by adversity, limited facilities

and a chance discovery by his coach.

Born in the small village of ToranDongari near Nashik in Maharashtra, Gavit was just about six years of age when he lost his right arm after an injury from falling off a tree turned into gangrene due to lack of timely medical care.

The amputation of his arm below the elbow was a devastating blow to him and his family of farmers with limited means. However, he refused to let that define his life and turned his focus to running.

With limited access to training infrastructure in his hometown, it seemed like an unlikely path until coach Vaijanth Kale spotted his potential.

"I saw him at school and then I convinced his parents for training," Kale said after the triumph.

"He did not know anything about para competitions. He was competing in able-bodied events and was doing well," he recalled.

The 21-year-old Basil, on the other hand, was born with limb deficiency. The Kerala youngsters is supported by his parents and two brothers.

After his historic win, Gavit admitted that the start was not ideal but he grew stronger through the race.

"The start was a bit slow, but then I gradually picked up pace and it felt great to win," Gavit said.

(PTI)

Sreeshankar leaps into history with second straight CWG long jump medal



APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ Glasgow

Murali Sreeshankar became the first Indian long-jumper to win two successive medals at the Commonwealth Games as he once again claimed a silver at the event with a confident performance which showed that his two-year battle with a career-threatening knee injury was now well and truly over.

Having claimed his first silver in Birmingham in 2022, the 27-year-old added another to his collection after producing a best leap of 8.09 metres, capping an emotional comeback from the knee surgery that nearly derailed his career in 2024.

Before Sreeshankar, the country's only medallists in the event were Suresh Babu (men's bronze, 1978), Anju Bobby

George (women's bronze, 2002) and M Prajusha (women's silver, 2010). Sreeshankar was understandably elated. "Very happy, very grateful for being here as well. Very grateful for being able to represent India at the global stage ever again. Two years ago, I didn't think that probably I'll be in Glasgow and represent my country," said the Kerala man, who is coached by his father S. Murali — a former triple jump athlete.

Sreeshankar, however, could not hide his disappointment at not being able to bag a gold medal this time.

"I wanted to redeem the silver medal from Birmingham to gold. So, I am not satisfied with my performance. I have to keep improving my game, keep improving my skills," he said.

But he hoped that the momentum he has built here will come in handy for him at upcoming Asian Games in Japan.

"I have to work on my technique. But I feel that this is like a stepping stone, it will add confidence going ahead for the Asian Games," he noted. Former world champion Tajay Gayle of Jamaica clinched the gold with a best jump of 8.15m, while local favourite Stephen Mackenzie grabbed the last spot on the podium with an 8.08m effort. The medal was sweet considering where Sreeshankar stood just over a year ago. A ruptured patellar tendon in April 2024 forced him to undergo surgery, and miss Paris Olympics raising doubts over whether he would ever return to his best. But here, he made another emphatic statement of resolve.

Competing in only his second CWG after missing 2018 edition due to appendix surgery, Sreeshankar opened confidently with a leap of 8.03m before stretching it to 8.09m in his second attempt to move into the lead.

(PTI)



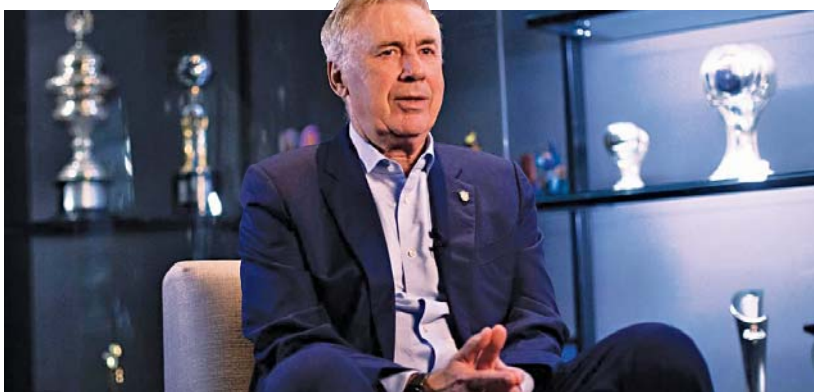
2028 Olympics important for Brazil's next World Cup team: Coach Carlo Ancelotti

MAURICIO SAVARESE ■ Rio de Janeiro

Brazil coach Carlo Ancelotti is still recovering from his team's round-of-16 loss to Norway in the World Cup. But as the 67-year-old Italian turns to the next four years on the job, he pledges to closely watch youth division players and the country's squad at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics to spearhead an overhaul.

Ancelotti also said in an exclusive interview with The Associated Press at the headquarters of the Brazilian soccer confederation in Rio de Janeiro that the five-time World Cup winners don't need to copy defending champion Spain or high-powered France to win a sixth.

"We don't need to copy - we need to learn where we can improve," Ancelotti said in the confederation's museum where much of Brazil's national team sil-



verware is kept.

"Some positions are well-covered, both in defence and attack. We are looking for improvement and development among the midfielders. And the Olympics could be a crucial moment

(to find players.)"

Ancelotti, who returned to Brazil on Sunday, has heard a lot about the Tokyo Olympics gold medal match since he arrived. Five years ago, Brazil beat Spain

2-1 to defend its title. Eight of the Spanish players in that game plus coach Luis de La Fuente and are now World Cup winners, but Brazil only took midfielder Bruno Guimaraes and striker Mathheus Cunha to the 2026 World Cup.

"We are in contact with the U-15, U-17, and U-20 coaches to identify talent and track their progress, ensuring they are prepared for the next World Cup," Ancelotti said. "Four years ago, Rayan was playing U-17. It is vital to look at youth development now so that by 2030 we have another generation of players progressing like him."

Many Brazil fans might not be that patient; they often expect stars to deliver and players to have leading roles wherever they play. But Ancelotti says the set up he plans is different from that.

"At this moment, football doesn't

need one single star - we need to reinforce concept of the team," coach said.

"Brazil doesn't have a single reference point right now, and it doesn't need one. We have many great players. The goal is to build a strong, cohesive team."

Three friendlies, two against Australia in September and one against India in October, will mark the beginning of the new cycle for Brazil's first-ever fulltime foreign coach. He knows pressure will be on until the 2028 edition of Copa America.

Ancelotti says a combination of players that make it to the continental tournament and those younger going to Los Angeles could make 2030 WC roster.

Striker Neymar, who made Ancelotti's squad for this summer's tournament despite serious doubts about his fitness, is not in coach's plans going forward. The 34-year-old star repeated earlier this

week that he thought his time with the national team was over.

"That's part of the natural trajectory of a great talent like Neymar," Ancelotti said. "It is like it is for others who finish an important time with the national team. We spent little time together, but I have only good things to say. He was serious, professional, he helped in whichever way he could. Too bad he had this injury that did not allow him to be 100 per cent since the first game." Ancelotti said his decision to coach Brazil until 2030 and reject an offer from Italian soccer federation to take the same job in the same national team he played for "has nothing to do with contracts, it has to do with commitment."

Italy soccer executives said Brazil's coach was in considerations for the position, which ultimately went - once again - to Roberto Mancini.

(AP)

India sweep men’s, women’s titles at Commonwealth TT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Manush Shah produced a heroic performance as India’s men’s team overcame a resilient Malaysia 3-2 in the final to lift the 22nd Commonwealth Table Tennis Championships title in New Delhi on Thursday. Earlier, the women’s squad thrashed Malaysia without breaking a sweat, wrapping up the final with a 3-0 verdict at the Thyagaraj Stadium. It was a tricky final for the men’s team, especially after their loss to Malaysia in the league phase. India left out Harmeet Desai from the lineup, while the Malaysians brought in their second player to play the third rubber.

The tie appeared headed for a comfortable Indian win after Manav Thakkar raced to a 2-0 lead over left-handed Qi Shen Wong in the fourth rubber. However, the Malaysian, ranked No. 204, staged a remarkable comeback to beat world No. 41 Manav 2-3 and level the contest at 2-2, leaving the title to be decided by the fifth and final



rubber featuring world No. 40 Manush Shah. Manush, who had earlier beaten Wong in a five-game battle after recovering from a 4-7 deficit in the decider by winning seven straight points, carried that confidence into the

decisive match. He dominated from start to finish against Javen Choong, securing a comfortable straight-game victory to seal the gold medal for India. In the women’s final, India blanked Malaysia 3-0.

MLS Commissioner Don reflects on WC, league’s growth and stepping down



ANNE M PETERSON ■ New York

When the World Cup first came to the United States in 1994, it spurred the creation of Major League Soccer. Now, in the wake of this summer’s tournament, big changes are afoot for the league. After this season, MLS will begin transitioning to a summer-to-spring calendar, bringing the league in line with most of its international counterparts. There’s also talk of adjusting roster rules and the salary cap to make the league more competitive on the global stage.

And, MLS is preparing for the departure of Commissioner Don Garber, who has overseen the league over a period of tremendous growth since taking on the job in 1999.

There have already been signs MLS is seeing the so-called World Cup bump, with MLS ticket sales up 58 per cent in the 40 days during and after the World Cup compared to the same period before the tournament, according to the league. The recent addition of international stars like Robert Lewandowski, who joined the Chicago Fire, and Antoine Griezmann, now with Orlando City, has provided an additional boost.

“When I look at the World Cup, I look at it as an eight-year journey that delivered everything we could have imagined during the actual tournament, and now, as you know, it’s our job to take it from here and continue as much of that momentum as possible, so that our teams have more fans, we have players that continue to pick MLS as a league of choice. We’re developing more skilled players in our MLS Next program, and in our MLS academies, and on and on,” Garber said in an interview with The Associated Press ahead of MLS All-Star Game on Wednesday.

In a way, this is something of a full-circle moment for Garber, who attended his first soccer match during the 1994 World Cup. This time around, he attended 15 matches over the course of the tournament. (AP)

Sajan Prakash fails to qualify for 200m freestyle finals



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Glasgow

Seasoned Indian swimmer Sajan Prakash failed to qualify for the men’s 200m freestyle finals at the Commonwealth Games, signing off a disappointing fifth in his heat and 20th overall in Glasgow on Wednesday. Only the eight fastest swimmers advance to the final and Sajan was way off the mark at 1:51.99 seconds. His personal best and the National Record stands at 1:46.61

seconds. The 32-year-old finished behind debutant compatriot Aneesh Gowda, who too failed to move ahead by ending 18th overall with a timing of 1:51.64 seconds.

Gowda’s performance was marginal improvement on his personal best of 1:51.88secs but it was never going to be enough as the fastest time recorded was 1:45.69sec by England’s James Guy. The slowest qualifier was another Englishman, Thomas Dean, who clocked 1:47.46sec.

Para cyclist Lisha Das finishes last in 4,000m individual pursuit qualification



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Glasgow

Teenage Indian para cyclist Lisha Das bowed out after finishing sixth and last in the women’s C4-C5 4,000m individual pursuit qualifying event at the Commonwealth Games here on Thursday.

The 16-year-old, the youngest athlete in India’s contingent and the country’s only para-track cyclist to qualify for the Games, clocked 6:58.000 in the qualification round, averaging 34.450 kmph. Her time was well off the pace set by the

leading contenders.

Australia’s Tara Neyland topped the qualification standings in 4:45.796, while England’s Morgan Newberry secured the second spot in 5:06.470 to book a place in the gold medal race.

New Zealand’s Nicole Murray (5:06.878) and Australia’s Erin Normoyle (5:294.264) qualified for the bronze medal contest. Under the event’s qualification format, the two fastest riders advance to the gold medal race, while the third and fourth fastest riders compete for bronze.

Rahane announces retirement from international cricket

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Senior batter Ajinkya Rahane, who famously led an injury-ravaged Indian team to an improbable Test series win over Australia during a 2020-2021 tour, announced his retirement from international cricket on Thursday, saying that the time is right for him to move on.

The 38-year-old played 85 Tests, 90 ODIs and 20 T20Is for India in a career which began in 2013. He did not turn up for the country after the 2023 away Test series against the West Indies but maintained even until this year’s IPL that he would not give up on the dream of a comeback.

“The reality of life is that everything has a beginning, and everything has an end. When that time comes, you simply have to respect it and move

forward. I always relied on timing in my batting, and I’ve always understood its importance,” Rahane said in a video message. “Today, I feel the timing is right for me to move on and announce my requirement from international cricket, and all formats,” he added.

The batter scored 5,077 runs in Tests at 38.46 with 12 centuries and 26 fifties, while in 90 ODIs, he made 2,962 runs at 35.26 including three tons and 24 fifties. In 20 T20Is, Rahane made 375 runs.

Rahane’s biggest moment came in 2021 when he stood in for regular skipper Virat Kohli as a heavily depleted India defeated Australia in their own backyard 2-1 for the Border-Gavaskar Trophy.

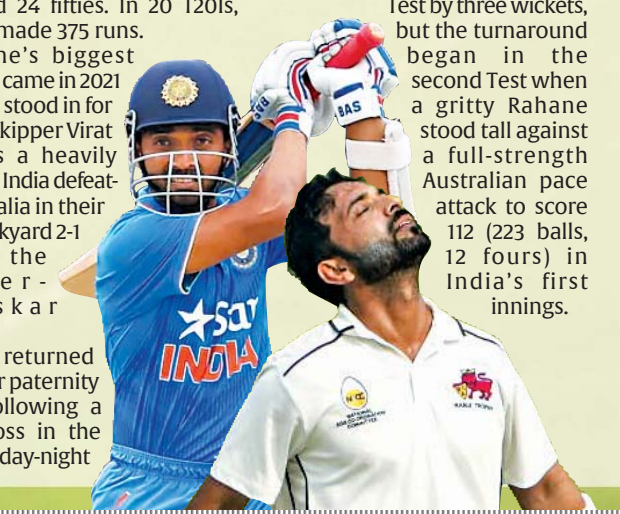
Kohli returned home for paternity break following a heavy loss in the opening day-night

Test in Adelaide in which India were embarrassingly bowled out for 36 in the second innings.

Rahane then took over India captaincy for the remainder of the series which they clinched despite missing some key players like Jasprit Bumrah and Ravindra Jadeja due to injuries.

The gutsy triumph included India’s famous win at The Gabba in Brisbane in the fourth and final

Test by three wickets, but the turnaround began in the second Test when a gritty Rahane stood tall against a full-strength Australian pace attack to score 112 (223 balls, 12 fours) in India’s first innings.



2027 ODI World Cup will be played across 12 venues, featuring 8 in South Africa

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Johannesburg

Twelve venues across South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia will stage the 2027 ODI World Cup, with hosts South Africa accounting for eight of the stadiums, the ICC announced on Thursday.

The marquee 50-over competition returns to Africa after 24 years. Back in 2003, South Africa, Zimbabwe and Kenya hosted the eighth Men’s Cricket World Cup. A spectacular ceremony in Johannesburg saw eight cities across South Africa, three in Zimbabwe and Namibia’s capital Windhoek unveiled as co-hosts for the tournament.

Also present to mark the momentous occasion were South Africa cricketing icons Graeme Smith, Makhaya Ntini, Hashim Amla, Temba Bavuma and Kagiso Rabada, alongside Zimbabwe’s Hamilton Masakadza and Namibia’s Rudolf Jansen van Vuuren.

The eight venues in South Africa are Wanderers Stadium (Johannesburg), Centurion (Tshwane), Newlands Cricket Ground (Cape Town), Kingsmead Cricket Ground (Durban), St George’s Park (Gqeberha), Mangaung Oval



(Bloemfontein), Boland Park (Paarl), Buffalo Park (KuGompo City, formerly known as East London).

The three venues across Zimbabwe are Harare Sports Club (Harare), Queens Sports Club (Bulawayo) and newly constructed Fale Mosi-oa-Tunya International Cricket Stadium (Victoria Falls). The matches in Namibia will be played at the Namibia Cricket Ground (Windhoek).

“The return of this prestigious tournament to Africa after 24 years is a landmark moment for cricket. We are confident that South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia will deliver an unforgettable event, showcasing the warmth, passion and rich diversity that make this region truly unique,” ICC chairman Jay Shah was quoted as saying in a press release.

India beat Namibia to seal second straight win in men’s pairs lawn bowls

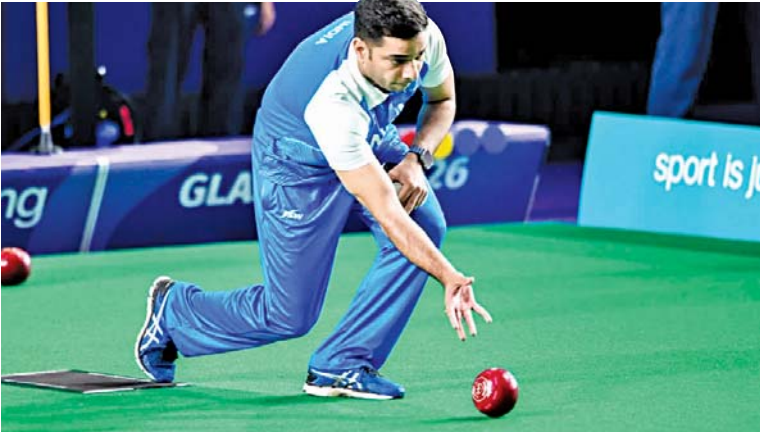
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Glasgow

India continued their impressive start to the lawn bowls competition at the Commonwealth Games with a hard-fought victory over Namibia in the Men’s Pairs Section B Round 2 Match 2 here on Wednesday. Building on Tuesday’s dramatic tie-break win over Cook Islands, the Indian duo of ‘lead’ Navneet Singh and ‘skip’ Dinesh Kumar displayed remarkable composure to come from behind and clinch the opening set 5-3.

Namibia looked in control after racing to a 3-0 lead, but the Indian pair responded with a superb run of precise deliveries and tactical play.

Navneet and Dinesh seized the momentum by scoring five points on the trot, turning the set on its head and leaving their opponents with little room for a comeback. The second set was far more straightforward for the Indians, who dominated proceedings from the outset.

They established an early 2-0 advantage and steadily extended it to



6-1 with consistent shot-making and effective control of the jack.

Namibia managed to pull back two points late in the set to narrow the margin to 6-3, but the result was never in doubt as the Indians comfortably closed out the contest to register their second successive win in the group stage.

India’s Nayanmoni Saikia produced

a commanding performance to defeat Isle of Man’s Caroline Whitehead 2-0 in the Women’s Singles Section C Round 2, Match 3.

Saikia dominated the opening set 11-2 to seize control of the contest before maintaining her superiority throughout the second set, winning it 7-4 to complete a comfortable straight-sets victory.

Age is just a number: Saransh Jain on maiden Test call-up at 33

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Age is just a number for uncapped off-spin allrounder Saransh Jain who at 33 years has earned his maiden Test call-up for the upcoming Sri Lanka tour on the back of consistent performances in the domestic circuit and India A.

With Washington Sundar not available due to a hamstring injury, the selectors picked the Madhya Pradesh spinner for the two-Test series beginning August 15.

“Age is definitely just a number,” Jain said on JioStar.

Only two Indians – Robin Singh and Rakesh Shukla – have made Test debuts after 33 since 1995 and Jain is likely to follow suit. “33 is just a number because of the fielding standards these days,



which are so high that your age doesn’t show on the field.

“I knew, if I hadn’t made it into the Indian team today, I would have played in the next year or two, but I was certain I’d make it.” Representing Central Zone, Jain

was the Player of the Tournament with 136 runs and 16 wickets in their triumphant campaign last season. He took eight wickets and scored a first-innings century in their six-wicket win over South Zone in the Duleep Trophy final

last year.

The left-hander has two first-class hundreds from 54 matches as he is known for his defensive as well as aggressive approach.

Remembering his journey, he said: “In 2014-15, I made my Ranji debut and took a five-wicket haul in my very first game against Tamil Nadu, a side which featured senior players like Dinesh Karthik.

“That made me realise cricket isn’t as difficult if you put in hard work and are disciplined. From then on, I knew if I wanted to play at a higher level, I had to focus on things which I can control.

“I kept doing that, and today I’m here representing India,” added Jain, who has 2223 runs at an average of 31.75 and 188 wickets at 27.30 in first-class matches.

“Ever since my age-group days, my main weapon has been consistency, to be able to hit the same spot repeatedly because the batsman will eventually take a risk to score.

“I’m not overthinking how the pitches will behave in Sri Lanka or how many wickets I’ll get; I just want to stick to my basics.” Jain idolises Ravichandran Ashwin and Harbhajan Singh who was there to help him out during a camp at the Bengaluru-based Centre of Excellence. “During the one-week camp at the Centre of Excellence, I learned a lot from Harbhajan Singh. Skill-wise, they told me I didn’t need major tweaks since I already have plenty of match experience.

“But one piece of advice from him really stuck with me, ‘You don’t have to lose something to gain something. You have to put

in the work.’ That stayed with me, and whenever I push myself through hard work, those words resonate deeply.”

But Jain’s ultimate idol has been his father Subodh Jain, also an offspinner with nine first-class games for MP under his belt. “I started playing cricket because of my father... I play cricket for him, and he is my ultimate idol.”

His India dream was only realised through the unwavering support and sacrifices of his family, he further said.

“It isn’t easy to make it into the 15-member Indian squad among millions of people, so family support is vital. “There were times when family issues happened where I could have broken down, but my family stood by me, managed everything, and stayed together. Because of them, I’m playing for India today.

Against all odds, Majid Magray set to lead India at Lord’s

HIMANK NEGI/SANSKRITI GAUBA ■ New Delhi

For years, every training session meant travelling more than 50 kilometres as there was hardly any infrastructure for differently abled cricketers in Kashmir.

The long commute, limited facilities, and five years of waiting for an India cap could have broken Majid Magray’s resolve. Instead, they shaped the player who will now lead India in the upcoming Mixed Disability Cricket Series against England, culminating at the iconic Lord’s Cricket Ground on August 19.

“I started in 2018. Our infrastructure is very limited in Kashmir. We have to travel 50-60 kms for practice. We have to prepare well. We have to play here and there. It is a big thing for us,” Majid told PTI. The 16-



member Indian team, announced by the Differently Abled Cricket Council of India (DCCI), will play a seven-match T20I series across Derby, Leicester, Hove, Arundel, and Lord’s from August 5 to 19.

For Majid, captaining India is the culmination of a journey that began in 2018 and tested his patience before he finally made his debut in 2023.

“You will only move forward

when you face difficulties. I was trying to join the team since 2018. I struggled for five years. My family supported me. My father and mother supported me; my brother also supported me a lot. It is like a dream to play at Lord’s,” he said.

The Jammu and Kashmir cricketer believes disability cricket has evolved rapidly since India won the Physical Disability World Series in 2019.